The Untold Story of Innovation, Betrayal, and Success that Can Teach You to Become the Market Leader

Guidelines and Definitions for the Book

This is a unique hybrid-genre book, blending a novella-style story about Rob Ryan's life with an entrepreneurial guide that includes the principles of the Sunflower Code, a business framework developed by Rob Ryan.

The content of this book is based on the following sources:
1. The dramatic film script I wrote and directed stored in the file titled: "*Document 1 – Film Script: The Man Who Saved the Internet with a Sunflower."*

2. A draft book written by Michael Levin about Rob Ryan, stored in the file titled: "Document 2 – Michael Levin's Book Chapters 1-13."

3. A guidebook on the Sunflower Code, stored in the file titled: "Document 3 – V4 Sunflower Manuscript."

4. The script for the film *License2Dream*, stored in the file titled: "Document 4 – Film Script: License2Dream."

5. The app scripts for *License2Dream*, stored in the file titled: "Document 5 – License2Dream App Scripts."

The goal of this book is to serve as a digital book where readers can engage with the content in multiple ways:
1. **As a narrative drama/novella**
2. **As a guidebook on the Sunflower Code**
3. **As a combination of both (drama and guidance) **

In the full digital version of the book, there will be embedded "expansion buttons" within the text. If a reader clicks on one of these, they will access additional content such as videos, audio clips, articles, and more, expanding on the topic at hand.

Writing approach:
1. **Writing the full chronological narrative** of Rob Ryan's story.
2. **Adding extensions** to the narrative to create a teaching tool and provide resources that will help entrepreneurs make better decisions and avoid mistakes. Like any entrepreneur, Rob Ryan made both good and bad decisions, and through his story, we hope to provide valuable insights to millions of entrepreneurs worldwide, especially young ones, to help them achieve significant success.

One of the key principles Rob Ryan emphasizes is that everyone must strive to be the "king" or "queen" of their chosen field.

Golden Rules for Writing the Book:
1. **Avoid unnecessary length. **
2. **Keep the story engaging and compelling. **
3. **Maintain the humor that characterizes the protagonist. **
4. **Focus on dialogues and minimize lectures. **

The Path to Becoming the "King Of"
Introduction to the Sunflower Code Story

The ballroom was packed with Silicon Valley's finest—visionaries, innovators, and titans of the tech world. The prestigious Ernst & Young awards ceremony was in full swing, and the air buzzed with anticipation. Yet, at the table marked *Ascend Communications*, only two seats were occupied. Rob Ryan sat with his wife, Terry, by his side. The other chairs, meant for his team, remained conspicuously empty. The silence between them was telling. None of his colleagues had shown up. It wasn't a mistake—someone had ensured it. A final twist of the knife that had been lodged in his back for months.

Rob's mind raced back through the years, to where it all began. He remembered his childhood in the Bronx, the joy he found at Cornell, and the bitter sting of betrayal when his professor handed his thesis idea to another student. He remembered the struggles to maintain relationships with his bosses, the successes of his technologies, and the trusted partners who had stood by him—at least until the going got tough.

Where were they now? Jim, Mike, Stacy... all of them had disappeared, jumping ship when the waters got rough, leaving Rob to weather the storm alone. This moment should have been a celebration, but instead, it felt bittersweet.

And there was Terry, sitting quietly by his side, just as she always had. She was his anchor, his confidante. She had weathered the betrayals, the heartbreaks, and even when he had made the impossible decision to let her go... —but let's not make a spoiler here!

Suddenly, the ballroom fell silent. The host's voice echoed across the room:
"Ladies and Gentlemen, it's time to award the winner of the Ernst & Young Silicon Valley Entrepreneur of the Year in Communications Technology Award. Mr. Rob Ryan."

Rob was stunned. For a moment, he sat frozen, unsure if the recognition had finally come. Was this the acknowledgment he'd been waiting for, after all the battles and sacrifices? As he stood to make his way to the stage, a flood of emotions washed over him. This wasn't just about the award; it was about the journey that had led him here. More than any other moment, it was the creation of the *Sunflower Code* that had paved the way to this success. It had made him the *king* of his field.
The *Sunflower Code* wasn't just a tool—it was a revelation. And it wasn't only Rob who benefited from it. Many entrepreneurs followed in his footsteps, using the same principles to achieve their own remarkable successes.

This book will take you through that story. It will show you how Rob Ryan revolutionized not just the internet but the very way we think about entrepreneurship. The lessons from the *Sunflower Code* turned Ascend Communications into a $24 billion powerhouse, and they continue to inspire those who dare to dream big.

With these seven powerful steps woven into the story, many have become—and will continue to become—the *king* of their industry, turning their passions into triumphs. This book might even be considered a new genre—a blend of drama and tutorial. After all, what better life stories are there than those that teach us a lesson?

The Meeting of Two Minds.
A prologue

The first time I met Rob Ryan was at a seminar he was giving on the "Sunflower Code" in Hawaii. I remember sitting there, listening to his talk—this brilliant entrepreneur with a deep capitalist mindset, speaking passionately about how his code had revolutionized the world of business. And as soon as the seminar ended, I walked up to him and said the words that would kickstart one of the most meaningful relationships of my life: "I don't like people like you—capitalists with no sense of social responsibility."

That moment, which could have ended in an argument, became the foundation of a deep friendship and an even deeper partnership. Rob, with his razor-sharp focus on entrepreneurship and economic success, and me, with my creative drive and passion to reshape human society through the power of media. It seemed like a mismatch at first, but the more we spoke, the more we realized that together, we had something extraordinary to offer the world.

That chance encounter led to countless collaborations. First, we created "License2Dream", an educational program for students that combined our skills to teach the younger generation about entrepreneurship through 3D and interactive media. Then came The Man Who Saved the Internet with a Sunflower, a dramatic film that told the untold story of Rob's journey and how the Sunflower Code not only saved the internet but reshaped the landscape of technology and innovation.

And now, we bring you this book—a culmination of our shared journey, our experiences, and the countless lessons we've learned along the way. This book is not just about Rob's "Sunflower Code"; it's about how two very different people, from different worlds, joined forces to turn their ideas into reality. Together, we've set ambitious goals for the next decade, and we're just getting started.
Rob, as some of you may know, is investing heavily in anti-aging technology, so our plans include sticking around for quite a while! There's a lot of work to do, and as the old saying goes, "Two are better than one." But in our case, we like to think "four are better than two"—because we can't forget our incredible partners, Terry and Irit, who have been with us every step of the way, making this journey richer and more meaningful.
This is our story, and it's far from over.

Ori Yardeni

Chapter 1: Seeds of Strategy

"What do you think you're doing, kid?" The man's voice cut through the quiet of the golf course. Rob, always quick on his feet, had just plucked a ball from the rough and was turning it over in his hand—a pristine white golf ball, practically new.

Except, it wasn't his.

He glanced up and saw the golfer storming toward him, his face twisted in anger.

"That's my ball! I'm about to hit my next shot!"

Rob wasn't the type to flinch, even when confronted. He quickly weighed his options, his mind already calculating the strategies.

"Didn't seem like you were going to find it... so, I tried to help you," he muttered under his breath. He tossed the ball back casually. "Here, take it. But if you lose it again, don't worry... there are plenty of fresh balls in the pro shop."

The man muttered something as he walked away, shaking his head. Rob smirked to himself, his mind already racing to the next move. He knew how to push the envelope, but he also knew when to back off and live to fight another day.

Rob made his way back to the pro shop, where Mr. O'Reilly, the manager, stood behind the counter.

"Mr. O'Reilly, got another batch for you," Rob said, placing a handful of golf balls on the counter.

"You've been busy, haven't you, lad?" O'Reilly chuckled, counting the balls. "Just don't ruffle too many feathers out there. Players don't like losing their balls."

"Just trying to make an honest living," Rob replied with a grin. "Besides, I'm only picking up the ones they've forgotten about."

O'Reilly shook his head but smiled. "You're a smart one, Rob. Keep playing fair, and you'll go far."

But life wasn't always fair, and Rob knew that well. His challenges that day weren't over yet. On his way home, he rounded the corner and heard the familiar sound of taunting voices. Too late to change direction—they'd seen him. It was the neighborhood kids again, bored and looking for trouble.

"Hey, brainiac!" one of them called out. "Still got your nose in those books?"

Rob held his breath, his silence becoming a shield.

"Hey Ryan, what're you working on... inventing the wheel?" another sneered.

"None of your business," Rob replied without looking up.

“He’s a math freak... a new Einstein... lost in dreams,” one mocked.

Rob’s Irish temper flared. “It’s called thinking ahead. You should try it sometime.”

The kid’s face twisted into a scowl. Rob knew where this was heading. They hated that he was different—that he thought faster, moved quicker. The boys closed in, but Rob didn’t wait for them to make the first move.

"Strike first," he thought, recalling his father’s words.

Without hesitation, Rob lunged at the biggest one, landing a solid punch. The kid doubled over in shock, and Rob bolted, running at full speed. The boys gave chase, but Rob was two steps ahead, making sharp turns through the maze of side streets. He wasn’t running out of fear—he was running with a plan. Every twist and turn was calculated to throw them off. His mind raced faster than his legs, processing every possibility. He was in control, playing the game on his terms.

Finally, he saw Mrs. Greenfield’s flower shop up ahead. With one last burst of speed, he ducked inside and crouched behind a row of flower buckets. The boys rushed past, none the wiser.

“Rob, hiding from trouble again?” Mrs. Greenfield stepped out from behind the counter, amusement in her voice.

“Not hiding. Just avoiding unnecessary complications,” Rob grinned, catching his breath. “Those bullies just can’t stand that I’m… different.”

Mrs. Greenfield gave him a knowing look. “Different is what makes you special, Rob. Don’t let them forget it. Here, take this sunny flower to your mom—surprise her with a message of love.” She handed him a sunflower from one of the buckets.

“Did you know sunflowers are smart?” Ten-year-old Rob said, his voice filled with certainty.

Mrs. Greenfield raised an eyebrow. “Smart? How can a flower be smart?”

“It’s all in how the seeds are arranged,” Rob explained, lifting one of the flowers to show her. “The spiral pattern follows the Fibonacci sequence. It’s nature’s strategy. The seeds are arranged in a way that maximizes space and ensures each one gets sunlight and room to grow. It’s efficient—nothing is wasted.”

Mrs. Greenfield blinked, clearly impressed. “You never stop surprising me, Rob. You see things the rest of us don’t.”

“Everything follows a pattern,” Rob said softly. “You just have to understand the strategy behind it.”

When he arrived home, his father sat at the kitchen table, wiping his hands after a long day.

“You’re late,” his father said, not looking up.

Rob dropped the cash from the golf course onto the table. “Made some money today.”

His father nodded approvingly. “Good. And what else?”
“Some kids tried to mess with me.”
“And?”
“I handled it,” Rob said, recalling how he’d struck first.

His father nodded. “Smart. But remember—when I say stand strongly, it doesn’t always mean throwing a punch. It means getting ahead of them. Strength isn’t just in your fists, Rob. It’s in your mind.”

Rob’s natural problem-solving skills began to flourish in school as well.

“Rob, you’re a natural problem-solver,” his math teacher told him one day. “But remember, the key to solving problems isn’t just having the right answer—it’s understanding why that answer works. If you understand that, you can solve anything.”

Rob wasn’t content just to fit into the system. “I don’t want to just solve problems,” he often thought. “I want to build something of my own.” And that would require more than just intelligence—it would require vision, strategy, and the ability to see what others couldn’t. To solve problems in a way that changes everything.”

It was this mindset that would eventually lead him to Cornell University, where his journey would truly begin.

Chapter 2: The Fire of Ambition

“Oh, I’m sorry! Didn’t see you there,” Rob said quickly, bending down to help pick up the scattered papers, after he accidentally bumped someone in Cornell's coffee shop.

“No problem,” came a voice from above him, soft but confident. “We all tend to become invisible around this place when we’re buried in our books.”

Rob looked up and saw a young woman with ginger hair with bright, curious eyes. She smiled, and for a brief moment, the chaos of the campus seemed to pause.

“I wouldn’t call you invisible,” Rob said, handing her the papers. “I mean, it’s not every day someone pulls me out of my thoughts.”

She laughed, a genuine sound that made Rob’s heart skip a beat. “Glad to know I made an impression. I’m Terry.”

“Rob Ryan,” he replied with a smile, standing up and offering his hand.

Cornell wasn’t just a place for academic rigor—it was a crucible. With every student pushing themselves to stand out, Rob knew that his advantage lay in his sharp mind and his ability to think ahead.

One day, after a particularly grueling engineering class, Rob noticed a group of students huddled around a set of blueprints in the library. His roommate, Mike, waved him over.

“Rob, check this out,” Mike said, pointing at the designs. “Professor Whitman’s final project. It’s impossible.”

Rob glanced at the schematics, his mind immediately racing. “It’s complicated, sure. But impossible? Da Vinci would disagree.”

“Seriously, man,” one of the students said. “You think anyone can solve this?”

Rob shrugged. “Good news is, if we all fail, we can blame Da Vinci.”

The group laughed, though tension hung in the air. This project was more than just a grade—it was a test of their ability to think, to strategize.

Later that evening, Rob sat in his dorm, staring at his own set of blueprints. No matter how many times he reviewed the calculations, something didn’t add up. Mike, lying on his bed, glanced over.

“Still stuck?” Mike asked, stretching. “You’ve got the brainpower, Rob. Maybe you just need to see it from a different angle.”

Rob sighed, rubbing his temples. “Yeah, well, Whitman’s not expecting angles. He’s expecting perfection.”

Mike sat up. “I’m serious. Sometimes, thinking outside the box isn’t about finding a solution—it’s about changing how you look at the problem.”

That got Rob’s attention. Mike was right. Maybe the problem wasn’t with the numbers themselves, but with how they were being approached.

As Rob pondered the problem, his eyes fell on a biography of Thomas Edison lying on his desk. He remembered a particular quote from Edison that had struck him earlier: “I have not failed. I’ve just found 10,000 ways that won’t work.” That sentence had stuck with Rob, resonating deeply with his own philosophy.

“Failures are just steps toward success,” Rob muttered to himself. Edison’s perspective wasn’t about avoiding mistakes—it was about embracing them as part of the process. Rob realized that maybe his approach to this project needed that same kind of shift in thinking. Instead of seeing the roadblocks as failures, they could be opportunities to find the real solution.

The next day in the library, Rob’s face lit up with a revelation. He stood abruptly, startling the student next to him.

“I’ve got it!” Rob exclaimed.

Mike, who had been half-asleep, sat up. “You cracked it?”

“Not exactly,” Rob grinned. “But I out-thought it. We’ve been focusing too much on the details. The key is seeing the bigger picture.”

Mike raised an eyebrow. “Bigger picture?”

Rob nodded. “We’re looking at this like a puzzle, but it’s more like a game. And in games, it’s not just about solving the pieces—it’s about the strategy behind them.”

As Rob leaned over the blueprint, deep in conversation with Mike and the other students, a familiar figure strolled past their table. Terry, carrying a stack of books, caught Rob’s eye and waved.

“Hey, Rob,” she called with a teasing smile. “Solving the mysteries of the universe again?”

Rob barely looked up. “Something like that. This thing’s a monster.”

Terry paused for a moment, then smiled softly. “Well, if you ever take a break from saving the world, they’re showing Romeo and Juliet in the student center tonight. Thought you might want to come with me.”

Rob blinked, not quite understanding. “Shakespeare, huh? I’m more into sci-fi and documentaries about black holes. Not really my thing.”

Terry's smile faltered slightly, though she kept it light. "Right, well... maybe another time. See you at the cafeteria?"

"Yeah, sure," Rob said absently, already turning back to the blueprint. Terry sighed, her smile turning a bit wry as she walked away.

Mike leaned over with a knowing grin. "You really have no clue, do you?"

"What?"

"A nice sharp girl is giving you a pleasant opportunity to make a break, and you do not jump to take it? you have a problem man…"

We've got bigger problems here, Mike," Rob replied, frowning at the paper.

Mike chuckled. "Yeah, bigger problems than Romeo and Juliet, apparently."

"Where are the missing bullets?" Rob asked, seemingly out of nowhere.

Mike blinked. "Bullets? Dude, what the hell are you talking about? Who are you going to shoot?"

"Don't you all know the story about the U.S. military that had this problem? They wanted to add armor to their planes, but they didn't know exactly were. So, they started looking at the planes that came back from battle—checking where the bullet holes were made …. They figured, 'Hey, more holes here, so that's where we reinforce.'"

"Well, that makes sense," one student chimed in. "Just cover the spots that took the most damage, right?"

"Wrong… this is the obvious…. and when something seems so obvious be careful…" Rob continued. "So then comes this guy, Abraham Wald, a mathematician. He asks a simple question: "Where are the missing bullets?"

The group stared at him, confused.

"What missing bullets?" Mike asked, raising an eyebrow.

"The ones on the planes that didn't come back," Rob said, letting the realization sink in.

There was a pause before one of the students finally spoke. "Wait... so, the planes that got shot down... their bullet holes were in different places?"

"Exactly," Rob nodded. "Wald figured out that the spots without bullet holes on the surviving planes were actually the most critical—those were the areas that needed reinforcing.
Those planes that made it back, their holes weren't the real problem. They came back and landed safe"

"Wow," Mike muttered, "that's... genius."

Rob leaned in, lowering his voice slightly. "Here's the thing—All the big-shot engineers thought they knew better… they didn't want to listen. They were focused on what they "could" see, not on

what was missing. But the guy in charge—he had the sense to listen. He understood the importance of considering every angle, especially the opinions of the minority."

The group was silent, soaking it in.

"So, what are you saying?" one of the students asked. "We're missing something?"

Rob grinned. "I'm saying that sometimes, the answer isn't where everyone's looking. It's where no one's thinking to look. That's how you win."

Later that evening, Rob spotted Terry sitting at a table in the campus café. He grabbed a coffee and joined her.

"So, how was the movie?" Rob asked casually, still thinking about the project.

Terry glanced up, her eyes flashing with playful mischief. "Oh, it was lovely. And my date seemed to enjoy it too."

Rob paused mid-sip, looking slightly confused. "Date?"

Terry smirked, watching as the penny dropped. "Yeah, you know, someone who actually likes Romeo and Juliet..."

Rob blinked, clearly not getting it, and shrugged. "Well, as long as he appreciates Shakespeare, I guess."

Terry leaned forward; her voice laced with sarcasm. "You know, Rob, not everything in life has to follow math"

Rob raised an eyebrow, intrigued. "What do you mean?"

Terry leaned back, crossing her arms. "Not everything can be figured out like a blueprint. Some things... like love... they just happen."

Rob chuckled. "Love? I'd argue that even love needs a comprehensive strategy."

Terry smirked, raising an eyebrow. "Oh really? So what's your grand strategy for love, Rob?"

Rob paused, thinking for a moment, before answering honestly. "Mmm... I've got nothing."

Terry grinned, clearly amused. "Exactly. Maybe it's time you come up with one."

Rob laughed, nodding in agreement. "Fair point."

Chapter 3: Breaking the Chains

The Intel auditorium buzzed with excitement. Engineers, executives, and industry leaders had gathered to honor one of their own. At the podium stood the president of Intel, smiling broadly as he addressed the crowd.

“Today, we’re here to recognize Rob Ryan, Intel’s Engineer of the Year for 1982!” he announced, the room breaking into applause. “Rob led the charge on a project that wasn’t just about solving a technical issue—it was about creating a global standard. Thanks to his work, Ethernet is no longer the Tower of Babel it once was. Instead of different systems unable to communicate, we now have a common language—a standard that will unite businesses and organizations worldwide."

The crowd’s applause grew, and Rob nodded from the side of the stage. The president continued, “Rob has been a driving force in digital communication, starting from his work at Los Alamos and Lawrence Livermore, all the way to Intel. And today, we celebrate his leadership in making Ethernet the backbone of internal communications.”

The applause continued as Rob stepped up to the microphone, accepting a gleaming trophy and an envelope with a handshake. He glanced at the white envelope and allowed a small smile to escape, but there was a flicker of uncertainty behind it.

“I appreciate the recognition,” Rob began, addressing the room. “But let’s be honest—it wasn’t just me. The team here at Intel, and our partners at Xerox, they’re the real heroes. Together, we’ve turned what was essentially organized chaos into something the whole world will use.”

He paused for a moment, the room still and attentive. “But for me, this isn’t the finish line. It’s the starting gun. We’ve laid the groundwork, but now we need to push further. We need to think about how all these local networks, these internal systems we’ve created, can be connected into something bigger. Imagine a river of information, flowing between organizations, connecting us all.”

There were nods in the audience, though many still couldn’t fully grasp what Rob was hinting at—the seeds of what would one day become the internet.

Rob glanced again at the envelope in his hand, his expression turning playful. “And, uh, I’m hoping that whatever’s in here,” he said with a slight grin, holding the envelope aloft, “shows Intel’s commitment to the future as much as mine is.” The audience laughed lightly at the joke, unaware that Rob was half-serious. He hoped the envelope contained stock options, a sign that Intel saw his value not just in the present, but in the long game.

He ended his speech with a final note: “This isn’t just about technology. It’s about where we’re headed. And if we keep thinking big, I have no doubt we’ll change the world.”

The applause that followed was loud and appreciative, but Rob’s mind was already racing forward, thinking about what came next.

After the ceremony, Rob stepped off the stage, a mix of pride and unease swirling inside him. As he shook hands with colleagues, he opened the white envelope he'd been given. Inside, a check for a few hundred dollars.

Seriously? He thought, staring at it.

Without hesitating, he marched straight to his manager's office, pushing open the door.

"I think you forgot something in here," Rob said, holding up the check.

The manager looked puzzled. "What do you mean?"

"Stock options," Rob shot back. "Like the ones you all received. I've just helped set a global standard—where are mine?"

The manager leaned back, uncomfortable. "Rob, stock options are reserved for vice presidents and senior management. You know that."

Rob's frustration flared. "This isn't about the money. It's about recognizing where things are headed. I know where I'm going. If Intel can't see that, fine. You'll regret letting me walk out that door."

Without waiting for a reply, Rob turned and stormed out, slamming the door behind him.

Here's a revised version of the dialogue between Rob and Terry, incorporating the dynamic you're aiming for:

Later that evening, Rob sat with Terry in their small apartment, staring out at the darkening skyline. His frustration simmered just beneath the surface.

"They gave me everything but the one thing that matters," Rob muttered, tossing the check onto the coffee table. "It's like they don't believe in me, don't believe in what I'm building. What's the point if I don't have a stake in the future I'm creating?"

Terry, ever calm, placed her hand on his, her expression thoughtful. "Rob, I know how much this means to you, but you can't keep letting your temper drive your decisions."

Rob shook his head, his voice rising. "What was I supposed to do? Stay there, let them toss me crumbs while they sit on top of my work? It's insulting, Terry."

She gave him a soft, steady look. "You're not wrong to want more. But you need to stop burning bridges every time something doesn't go your way. Next time, we'll make sure those stock options are in writing—before you sign anything."

Rob sighed, leaning back into the couch. "You think I overreacted?"

"I think you're brilliant," Terry said, smiling slightly. "But you've got to stop acting like you're at war with the world. You could've handled it better. And next time, you will."

Rob paused, taking in her words. “Maybe you’re right. It’s just... I’m tired of people not seeing the big picture.”

“And that’s why I’m here,” Terry said, her voice teasing but firm. “To help you navigate that big picture without blowing everything up in the process. The next job? We’ll make sure everything’s locked in. No more last-minute surprises.”

Rob looked at her, a small smile forming. “You always know how to cool me down, don’t you?”

Terry smirked. “Someone’s got to.”

Rob didn’t stay unemployed for long. Following his exit from Intel, he was more cautious this time. On Terry’s advice, he ensured that his new contract at DataStream Networks included stock options. It was a hard-learned lesson from his Intel days, where the lack of equity had left him feeling unappreciated. With this new clause in place, Rob believed he had finally outsmarted the system. He was confident that this time, he’d be properly rewarded for his work.

DataStream Networks brought Rob in to solve a regulatory standard issue—a problem they’d been wrestling with for over three years. Within months, Rob’s innovative approach had the project back on track. It was almost complete—a major milestone for the company, and Rob’s success was in sight.

But just as he began to feel secure in his role, everything came crashing down. His boss, Brad Shultz, had a different agenda. It became clear to Rob that the stock options he’d fought to include in his contract were now hanging by a thread—one that Brad was determined to cut.

The breaking point came one afternoon when Brad called Rob into his office.

“I need you to let Stevens go,” Brad said, not even looking up from his computer. “He’s not hitting his targets, and we need to make some tough decisions.”

Rob’s eyes narrowed. He had heard this before. “Stevens is one of the most talented engineers we have. He’s just misaligned in his role. Let me move him to another project. You’ll see what he’s capable of.”

Brad finally looked up, his expression unreadable. “This isn’t about talent, Rob. It’s about business. We’re not running a mentoring program here.”

Rob felt a familiar surge of frustration. “This is a mistake. You’re looking at short-term cuts and missing the bigger picture.”

Brad’s face darkened. “The only mistake I see is keeping you on as long as I have. You’re fired.”

Rob stood frozen for a moment, his mind racing. Then it hit him—the stock options. He had almost reached the vesting period. Almost.

“Let me guess,” Rob said, his voice low and filled with contempt. “This is about the stock options, isn’t it? You’re firing me right before they vest.”

Brad’s face remained impassive. “Business is business.”

Rob clenched his fists, taking a deep breath. “I busted my ass to fix a problem you couldn’t solve in three years, and now you’re cutting me loose to save a few bucks? You’ll regret this.”

Brad’s face remained impassive. “We’ll see.”

Rob took a step toward the door, but then paused. He turned back, his eyes locking onto Brad’s. “You know, Brad, this story won’t stay quiet for long. Engineers—good engineers—talk. Word gets around. Let’s see how many talented people will want to work for a boss who throws them under the bus the moment they show potential.”

Brad’s lips curled into a thin, dangerous smile. “You think you can hurt me, Rob? You think your little threats are going to make a difference?”

Rob held his gaze, unflinching. “You know how it works in Silicon Valley. Reputations matter. Yours might not recover.”

Brad stood up, leaning over his desk. “You want to play that game? Fine. But remember, Rob—there’s a saying for people like you: *he who laughs last, laughs best.*”

Rob’s stomach twisted at the words, but he didn’t let it show. He turned and left the office, slamming the door behind him. He had no idea what Brad meant by that cryptic statement, but he would soon find out.

Rob sat in the reception area of Multisystem Corp, his knee bouncing nervously as he waited for his first official day to begin. His briefcase rested on his lap, filled with the usual tools of the trade—notes, plans, and the burning ambition to prove himself once again. After what had happened with Brad Shultz at DataStream Networks, Rob was determined to make a fresh start.

Jim Baily, the hiring manager, emerged from the back office. His sharp appearance didn’t mask the unease in his eyes. Something about his smile was off—like it was forced.

“Rob?” Jim’s voice was polite but stiff.

Rob stood, extending his hand. “Jim, great to see you again.”

Jim hesitated for just a moment before shaking Rob’s hand. “Yeah, let’s head back to my office.”

As they walked through the hallway, Rob took in the outdated computer terminals and the hum of work. This company wasn’t exactly at the cutting edge, but that’s why he was here—to change that.

“I was thinking I could start by upgrading some of your communication cards,” Rob said casually, trying to ease the tension he was starting to feel.

Jim glanced sideways. “Let’s hold off on that for now,” he said.

Rob felt a knot tightening in his stomach. Something was definitely wrong.

“Is everything okay?” Rob asked as they neared Jim’s office.

Jim gave him a noncommittal nod and opened the door, gesturing for Rob to sit. The office was cluttered with prototypes and random tech gadgets, but none of that mattered right now. Rob sat down, watching Jim closely.

"Rob, you’ve got an incredible reputation,” Jim began. “You’re one of the best in networking. That’s why this is tough.”

Rob narrowed his eyes. “What’s tough?”

Jim sighed, sliding an envelope across the desk. “We’ve decided to go in a different direction.”

Rob’s heart dropped. “What do you mean, ‘different direction’? I haven’t even started! I barely know where the bathrooms are!”

Jim said nothing, motioning for Rob to open the letter. Rob’s hands shook as he pulled out the folded piece of paper. His eyes scanned it quickly, but he didn’t need to read it all. There it was at the bottom:

Brad Shultz, CEO, DataStream Networks.

Rob gritted his teeth. "That bastard…”

Jim didn’t respond.

Rob slammed the letter onto the desk. “I can’t believe this. Brad fired me because I wouldn’t do his dirty work. I refused to let go of one of my best engineers, and now he’s torpedoing my career by sending this letter around?”

Jim raised a hand. “Look, Rob, it’s not personal. But you’ve got a reputation now—someone who doesn’t play well with others, who doesn’t take orders.”

"That’s not the whole story!" Rob protested. "I solved a major regulatory standard for them that they had struggled with for three years, and Brad didn’t want to give me my stock options. So, he pulled that stunt right before they were supposed to vest.”

Jim shifted in his seat, clearly uncomfortable. “Do you think, maybe... you’ve got some control issues?”

Rob’s eyes flashed. “Control issues? I’m not a politician, Jim. I’m a damn good engineer.”

Jim gave a slow nod. “And no one’s denying that. But in Silicon Valley, Rob, it’s not just about being a great engineer. It’s about fitting in. It’s about being able to work in a team. And from what Brad says…”

Rob didn’t let him finish. “You want a ‘team player’? I helped create the Ethernet standard. Intel named me Engineer of the Year! That’s not just some participation trophy, Jim—that’s Silicon Valley’s stamp of approval.”

Jim sighed again, leaning back in his chair. “Look, I get it. But you’re going to need to figure this out. Because if you want to stay in this business, you’re going to have to play the game a little better.”

Rob stood up abruptly, accidentally knocking a prototype modem off the desk. It shattered on the floor.

Jim winced.

Rob stared at the broken pieces for a second before muttering, “Can’t even survive a three-foot fall? Lousy quality control…”

He grabbed his briefcase, ready to storm out, but before he could, Jim added, “Just so you know, Brad had a parting message: ‘He who laughs last, laughs best.’”

Rob froze, anger coursing through him.

“Yeah, we’ll see about that,” Rob muttered through gritted teeth as he walked out the door.

Chapter 4: "Trying to break Out of the circle"

Rob pulled into the garage of his townhouse, feeling the weight of yet another setback. The familiar sting of failure hung over him as he stepped inside, but he wasn't in the mood for another lecture.

Terry was there, dressed in her business suit, just about to leave for work. One glance at Rob's face told her everything she needed to know.

"Oh no... not again?" she sighed.

Rob walked past her into the kitchen, yanking open the fridge. "It's not me, it's them this time."

Terry followed him, folding her arms. "So you're blacklisted from every company in town now?"

"Seems like it." Rob cracked open a soda. "Maybe I should just stop trying."

Terry moved closer, placing a hand on his arm. "I didn't marry a quitter."

Rob scoffed. "Well, even your grandmother warned you that I'd never amount to anything." He gestured toward the framed photo of her grandmother on the shelf, smirking. "She's still giving me the evil eye, even from the grave."

Terry rolled her eyes but smiled faintly. "So suddenly she's the voice of God now?"

Rob shook his head, flipping the picture face down. "Maybe."

Terry sighed, turning back to the door. "You're going to be okay?" she asked as she headed to work.

"Sure, I'm on top of the world," Rob muttered sarcastically, as the door clicked shut behind her.

Days passed, and Rob's frustration deepened. Their house had become a disaster zone of pizza boxes, empty cans, and papers strewn everywhere. Rob lay slumped on the couch, staring blankly at the ceiling.

Terry walked in, surveying the wreckage. "Rob, seriously... what's going on?"

Rob stirred slightly but didn't move. "I'm taking a nap," he mumbled.

Terry raised an eyebrow. "Never a dull moment with you."

Rob groaned, clearly defeated. "I'm just tired, Terry. I can't catch a break.

Terry picked up a pillow and tossed it at him. "Get up. I've got something for you."

Rob dragged himself into the kitchen, his hair disheveled, looking defeated. On the kitchen table sat a large object, wrapped in plastic.

"What's that?" Rob asked, pulling off the plastic. "Whoa... a Lisa? From Apple? We can't afford this!" He stared at the early model Apple computer, one of the first personal computers ever made.

"It's used," Terry said as she rinsed dishes. "My firm was getting rid of it. I got it cheap."

Rob ran his hands over the machine, clearly impressed but also worried. "Still... a small fortune."

Terry turned, her expression serious. "Then maybe it's time you got off your ass and made use of it."

Rob raised an eyebrow. "And do what exactly?"

"I don't know... reinvent yourself. If working for other people isn't working out, maybe it's time to be your own boss."

Rob chuckled bitterly. "Oh, just like that?"

Terry smirked. "You're always saying you're going to be the king of something someday. Here's your chance."

Rob shook his head. "Right now, I'm the king of failure."

Terry rolled her eyes and handed him a book she had bought. "Here, maybe this will help."

Rob looked at the title: *"How to Raise Venture Capital 101."* He shook the book as if expecting money to fall out of it. "Doesn't seem to be working."

Terry laughed softly, heading to bed. "You'll figure it out."

That night, while Terry slept, Rob sat hunched over the old Lisa, struggling to get it working.

"C'mon... work, you piece of junk," he muttered, banging on the keyboard in frustration.

At 3 AM, Terry stumbled into the room, rubbing her eyes. "Rob? What's going on?"

Rob barely looked up. "I've got an idea."

Terry raised an eyebrow. "A new donut recipe?"

Rob laughed and shook his head. "No, I'm breaking out of the circle."

"The circle of...?" Terry asked, confused.

Rob grabbed a box of donuts from the counter and laid them out on the table. "Think of each donut as a university—each one using Ethernet to communicate internally, between departments on campus."

Terry sat down, curious. "Didn't you already get an award for that at Intel?"

"Yeah," Rob nodded. "But Ethernet only connects computers inside a local system. What if we wanted to connect universities in different cities—like Berkeley and Yale? Or even internationally, like The Sorbonne in Paris?"

Terry smiled, following along. "And this is...?"

Rob broke the donuts apart and connected them with small pieces, creating a wider circle around the original one. "This is wide area networking—the Internet. Global communication, faster and more efficient."

Terry leaned back, a smile spreading across her face. "I like the sound of that. 'The Communication Kingdom.'"

Rob chuckled. "Easier said than done."

Terry kissed him on the cheek. "I believe in you. Just don't smash that thing before you make it happen."

Rob nodded, feeling a surge of determination. He turned back to the Lisa, ready to make his vision a reality.

A few weeks later, Rob sat across from *Tim Kinsley*, a venture capitalist he had recently connected with, pitching his vision for the future of communication.

"I think it's brilliant," Tim said, leaning back in his chair. "But I have to ask... who's on your team?"

Rob blinked, caught off guard. "My team? It's just me right now."

Tim smiled. "Rob, no one's going to fund a one-man show. You need a team—engineers, salespeople, someone to manage operations. Investors need to know they're backing a complete operation, not just an idea."

"How am I supposed to hire anyone before I get the funding to do it?"

"That's not how this works," Tim said, chuckling. "You've got to build the team first, then get the funding. Investors want to know that the structure's there before they give you the money."

Rob left the meeting feeling more frustrated than ever. He had a groundbreaking idea but was still struggling to get the pieces in place.

It took months of late nights, rejections, and frustration, but with Terry's constant encouragement, Rob eventually pulled together a small team of engineers and a prototype. They began working on the project from their garage, with Rob's vision leading the way.

Finally, he found a backer: a venture capital firm in Boston, introduced to him by a friend of a friend.

"This is it," Rob told Terry one evening, as they celebrated the news with a bottle of wine. "We're really going to make this happen."

But just as quickly as the excitement came, it was dashed. The very next morning, the firm called back with a condition that made Rob's stomach turn.

"They want me to pre-sign a resignation letter," Rob said, pacing the kitchen as he relayed the news to Terry. "They want to be able to fire me if I don't perform. I can't do it, Terry. I can't have something like that hanging over me."

Terry sat down, listening quietly. "So what are you going to do?"

"I turned them down," Rob said, shaking his head. "No funding."

Terry sighed but nodded. "I understand."

It was a crushing blow, but Rob wasn't ready to give up. And just when it seemed like things couldn't get worse, another opportunity came knocking. This time, it was *Marty Allen* of ComputerVision, who had heard about Rob turning down the Boston firm.

"I like your guts," Marty said over the phone. "Let's talk about funding your idea."

And just like that, Softcom was born.

The early days of Softcom were filled with optimism, excitement, and long hours. Rob and his small team worked relentlessly to build something that would revolutionize how businesses communicated. They believed they were on the verge of something great.

But the realities of entrepreneurship soon set in. Despite all their hard work, the income wasn't there. Within a year and a half, Softcom was running out of money.

In the end, Rob couldn't keep Softcom afloat on his own. They would have to sell. With the help of *Steven Burill*, a well-known figure in the venture capital world, they found a buyer: *Digital Taras Communications* (Hayes Microcomputers).

It wasn't what Rob had dreamed of, but it was a lifeline. He would work for Digital Taras under a five-year contract. They would be moving to Georgia, and Rob would once again find himself working for someone else.

As they signed the papers and the deal was finalized, Rob looked at Terry, who smiled gently at him. "You've done well, Rob," she said softly. "You made the investors whole and built something from nothing. This is just the beginning."

But as Rob watched the ink dry on the contract, he couldn't help but feel the sting of defeat. He wasn't giving up—he never would—but he knew the journey was far from over.

Chapter 5: " The Road Back to Independence"

Life at "Digital Taras Communications" (DTC) was comfortable for Rob, at least on the surface. After selling "SoftCom" to the company, he was no longer burdened by financial worries, and all the engineers who had put their trust in him at "SoftCom" were well taken care of. Each of them saw their salaries significantly increase, which gave Rob a sense of responsibility for their success. But his five-year contract with *DTC* felt like a golden cage. The years ahead seemed endless, and Rob constantly wondered if he would ever be truly free.

The negotiation that led him to *DTC* still bothered him. Rob often found himself replaying his first conversation with *Tom Brown*, the CEO, and the frustration that followed.

"I don't want to buy a company, Rob," Tom had told him bluntly. "I'm offering you a job."

Rob, never one to shy away from confrontation, responded, "I'm not interested. SoftCom makes a great product. We've got an excellent team, and they've put their faith in me. If you're not willing to take care of the company and its people, we have nothing to discuss."

Tom smirked, leaning back in his chair. "Well, I could just wait for SoftCom to go bankrupt and hire you then."

"That's never going to happen," Rob shot back, his temper flaring. "If you don't buy SoftCom at a fair price and take care of everyone, you will never get me."

In the end, Tom agreed to Rob's terms, but the price was Rob's freedom. While Tom kept his promise financially, the creative freedom Rob had hoped for quickly evaporated. Tom wanted Rob to focus on improving *DTC*'s outdated products, while Rob's heart was set on developing the technologies of the future. The tension between their visions only grew stronger as time went on.

But the real breaking point came when *Tom Brown* brought his *mistress, Karla*, into the San Francisco office. It wasn't just the ethical dilemma of seeing Tom betray his wife; it was the professional complication of Karla's complete lack of skills for the role she was given.

"She's the new Director of Strategic Planning," Tom had said, a hint of arrogance in his voice. "I want you to work with her and make things... strategic."

Rob couldn't hide his disbelief. "Of course," he muttered through clenched teeth.

Tom glanced around Rob's office, his eyes settling on the neat stack of banker's boxes in the corner. "What are those for?"

Rob smirked. "Oh, those? They're for when you inevitably fire me. The last time I got canned, I couldn't get my books. I'm not making that mistake again."

Tom laughed, but it was a hollow sound. "I'm not going to fire you, Rob. In fact, I was thinking of making you my VP of engineering."

Rob wasn't buying it. "I've got my hands full here, Tom. Besides, Terry would kill me if I moved to Atlanta."

As the weeks went by, the situation with Karla worsened. She had no understanding of strategic planning, and Rob's team was forced to create the plans for her. Karla would then present them to the team in Atlanta, but her lack of knowledge was painfully obvious. Rob's best engineers, like *Rick Dull Bur*, were dragged along to explain every detail.

Meanwhile, the pressure at home mounted. Terry had long been uncomfortable with the relationship between Tom and Karla, and it was causing friction between her and Rob. Something had to give.

Then came the final straw. Tom walked into Rob's office one afternoon, his eyes narrowing as they fell on the familiar sight of the banker's boxes.

"Why are these boxes still here?" Tom demanded. "What's going on?"

Rob, never one to back down, placed his hand on top of the boxes and said, "Tom, you've always told me I'm secure here as long as I want the job. But I think you're going to fire me in about five seconds because I'm quitting."

"What?" Tom looked taken aback.

"I've done a lot of things wrong in my life, but I'm doing this one right. I'm leaving before things get worse, and I'm not going without my books."

Tom's face hardened. "What's going on, Rob? You think you can just walk out and start your own company?"

Rob shrugged, trying to hide the thrill of finally making his move. "I've got a few clever people outside, ready to help me move on. We're doing something new."

"You're not using my ideas, are you?" Tom sneered. "I've got NDAs signed by everyone in this building."

Rob couldn't help but laugh. "Your ideas? You haven't had a new idea since I started working here. I'm not stealing anything. We're building something from scratch."

"And who exactly is 'we'?" Tom asked, his voice dripping with sarcasm.

Rob didn't flinch. "Mike Bon, Stacy Higgins, and Rick Dull Bur*."

Tom's eyes narrowed, but then a slow smile spread across his face. "Stacy Higgins? That's rich. She's the one I fired months ago."

Rob knew Stacy was a genius, regardless of what Tom thought. To him, that was all that mattered.

"Well, Tom," Rob said, grabbing his boxes, "I guess this is goodbye."

Tom, still smiling, leaned in and whispered, "Don't think this is over, Rob. You'll be hearing from my lawyers. Pack your bags—you're headed to Atlanta for a deposition. And remember: the one who laughs last, laughs best."

As Tom walked out of the office, still chuckling to himself, Rob couldn't help but feel a mix of relief and exhilaration. He had finally broken free.

Outside, Rob's small team was waiting. The first steps toward building something new were already in motion. But Rob knew the battle with Tom wasn't over. Legal challenges were looming, and the road ahead would be rough.

But this time, he was ready.

Chapter 6: The First Steps into the Unknown

Rob's kitchen was warm, but the atmosphere was anything but. Papers were strewn across the wooden table, half-empty cups of coffee adding to the growing sense of desperation. Rob Ryan and his newly formed team of engineers sat in tense silence, each lost in their own thoughts. They had made a bold decision, leaving behind secure positions at Tom Brown's company to start something new. The problem was, none of them had any idea what that "something" was.

Stacy was the first to break the silence. "This is insane," she said, leaning back in her chair, arms crossed. "We've been at this for days, and we still have nothing. What the hell are we even going to pitch tomorrow?"

Mike, sitting across from her, glanced up from the sketch he'd been mindlessly doodling. "I think we should stick with what we know," he said, his voice tinged with frustration. "Faster data connections. It's the future. We all know it."

Stacy shot him a look. "And how exactly do we make money with that, Mike?"

The group fell silent again. It wasn't just that they didn't have a concrete product—they didn't even have a clear direction. Rob's wife, Terry, entered the kitchen, still dressed from her day at work, her briefcase slung over one shoulder. She immediately sensed the tension.

"Hey, everyone," she greeted them warmly, but no one looked up. Rob gave her a small nod of acknowledgment.

Rick, leaning forward now, was still trying to push his idea. "Data connectivity can apply to everything. Think about it—smart systems, remote work, logistics. We're talking big opportunities if we frame it right."

Stacy rolled her eyes. "Okay, name one system where that's going to make an immediate impact."

"Traffic," Rick replied confidently. "Imagine a world where data flows seamlessly through traffic systems, optimizing how trucks move across the country, minimizing congestion, cutting costs for companies. It's all about efficiency."

Stacy snorted. "Oh, sure. Investors will be falling over themselves to fund that—'Hey, let's count trucks on a bridge!'"

Terry stepped forward, placing a plate of cookies in the center of the table. "I don't know," she said, trying to soften the atmosphere. "That sounds kind of cool, actually."

Stacy glanced at the cookies and then at Terry. "Did you bake these yourself?" she asked, her tone shifting ever so slightly.

"Who has time for that?" Terry chuckled.

"If it were my husband," Stacy muttered under her breath, "I'd only bake from scratch."

Terry's eyes narrowed, her smile fading. "Well," she said, her voice steady, "you can do that when you find one."

The tension in the room spiked. Rob shifted uncomfortably, trying to refocus the conversation. “Look, I think what we need to figure out is what we do better than anyone else,” he said, his voice calm but firm. “What’s our edge?”

Rick leaned back in his chair, thinking. “It’s ISDN,” he said finally. “We know more about it than anyone out there.”

Stacy shook her head. “Yeah, great—ISDN. And what’s the point in offering services for an infrastructure that doesn’t even exist yet?”

“That’s the whole point,” Rob said, his voice rising with a spark of optimism. “If we develop a protocol for transferring data on ISDN lines now, we’ll have exclusivity when they are installed. We’ll be ahead of everyone else.”

Rick nodded enthusiastically. “Exactly! We could revolutionize data capacity. It’s not just about today; it’s about being the first to control tomorrow’s networks.”

Stacy laughed lightly, shaking her head in disbelief. “You two are living in the future,” she said, half amused, half annoyed. “We don’t even have basic infrastructure in place, and you want to pitch this to investors? You’re dreaming.”

Rob locked eyes with Stacy. “Dreaming or not,” he said, “we’ve got nothing else. And if we don’t start making bold moves, we’ll just be another group of ex-employees with nothing to show for it.”

Silence fell over the table again. Stacy pushed back from her chair and stood up. “I’ll sleep on it,” she said. “Maybe by tomorrow, I’ll feel less like we’re all jumping off a cliff.”

Rob nodded, his voice softening. “Sleep well. I’ll need you tomorrow.”

Stacy gave a half-smile, one that didn’t reach her eyes, and walked out. The door clicked shut behind her, leaving the rest of the team staring at the scattered notes in front of them.

Rick sighed heavily. “She’s such a buzzkill.”

Outside, through the window, Stacy could still hear the conversation. She paused, unlocking her bike but staying close enough to listen.

“She’s got this constant need to tear down any idea that’s not her own,” Rick said, leaning back in his chair.

Mike nodded in agreement. “Yeah, she’s tough. Cold, even.”

Rick scoffed. “You’d be cold too if your family invented something as boring as Ice Pops.”

Mike laughed. “How do you even invent an Ice Pop? It’s a stick and water.”

They all chuckled, but Rob stayed silent, rubbing his forehead with his hand. “Guys, come on. She’s the best programmer I’ve ever met. We can’t do this without her.”

The laughter died down, and the room grew quiet again. Stacy, standing outside, heard every word. She tightened her grip on her bike handles and pedaled off into the night, frustration and determination battling within her.

Back inside, Rob exhaled a long, weary breath. He turned to the kitchen, where Terry was already at the sink, rinsing the plates from dinner. The tension from the evening still hung in the air, thick and unspoken.

"You okay?" he asked quietly.

Terry didn't respond immediately, her hands busy scrubbing a dish. The sound of water running filled the silence, but it wasn't enough to mask the unspoken words lingering between them.

Finally, she spoke, her voice tight. "I didn't start it, you know."

Rob rubbed the back of his neck. "I know. Stacy can be... difficult."

Terry turned off the faucet and turned to face him. "She walks around here like she's untouchable. Like she knows everything. Well, I don't care how smart she is—she doesn't get to act like she's better than the rest of us."

Rob sighed, trying to defuse the situation. "Terry, she's just under pressure. She's alone in this. And you've got me. We're a family."

Terry's gaze softened slightly, but there was still something unsettled in her expression, her voice quieter this time. "Are we a family, Rob?"

The question hung in the air, heavy with implications Rob didn't want to face. He hesitated, then offered a weak smile. "We are, Terry. Of course we are."

Rob lingered there for a moment longer, feeling the weight of her words, but now wasn't the time. They had too much riding on tomorrow's presentation. He needed to focus. He stepped away, leaving Terry to finish up.

Presentation Day

The next morning, the team gathered outside the sleek office building of KLVC Venture Capital. Rob, Rick, Mike, and Stacy stood in a tight group, each of them carrying the weight of the day's significance. The night before had been rough, filled with late hours and last-minute changes to their pitch. But now, standing here in the bright morning light, the gravity of the moment was impossible to ignore.

Rob glanced at Stacy. She was focused, her usual sharp edge even more pronounced today. They hadn't spoken since she stormed out the previous night, but now wasn't the time to revisit that. They were a team, and right now, they needed to present a united front.

The receptionist greeted them warmly and ushered them into the conference room, where three investors sat waiting. Each of them impeccably dressed in tailored suits, their expressions unreadable as the team filed in.

Rob took a deep breath, feeling the familiar rush of adrenaline as they set up for the presentation. Mike fumbled with the easel, finally managing to get it to stand upright as he placed their first poster on it. It was upside down. A quiet curse escaped Mike's lips as he quickly adjusted it.

The lead investor raised an eyebrow but said nothing. Rob could feel the heat of the moment pressing down on him, but he forced himself to stay calm.

"Good morning," Rob began, his voice steady. "We are Ascend Communications, and we're here to talk about the future of data transmission."

He paused for a second, his eyes scanning the investors' faces, trying to gauge their reactions. They stared back at him, their faces impassive, waiting.

"The ISDN market," Rob announced, feeling proud as the letters flashed on the poster.

One investor raised his hand. "What's ISDN?"

"Integrated Services Digital Network," Stacy interjected smoothly. "All the large telephone companies are planning to switch over to it."

The investor looked at her intently. "Are you the CTO?"

There was a brief, awkward pause as everyone exchanged glances. Rob, thinking quickly, pointed to Stacy. "She's our CTO."

Stacy, who had been quietly observing until now, suddenly straightened, smiling as if Rob had finally recognized her worth. "That's right. I am the CTO."

The investors turned their full attention to her. "What does a new protocol for ISDN lines mean?"

"We're talking about a revolution in data capacity," Stacy replied confidently, her doubts from the previous night seemingly gone.

The second investor raised a hand, stopping the flow of the presentation. "You're asking us to invest in something you can't even fully prove will work. ISDN may never take off, and even if it does, you don't have the infrastructure to support it right now."

Rob cleared his throat, trying to regain control. "When the infrastructure is ready, we'll be the ones leading it. We're not just offering a product—we're offering a team that will build the future of data communication."

The investors exchanged skeptical glances. "On an ISDN market that doesn't exist yet?" one of them asked, his tone dripping with sarcasm.

"Yet," Rob replied with a slight chuckle.

The investors didn't look convinced.

One of them leaned forward. “I like your team,” he said, his voice lightly accented. “In fact, I love it. You are the most cohesive and driven group we’ve seen in a long time. But I do not like your business plan. I need you to pitch me something different.”

Rob blinked, caught off guard. “Right now?”

“Now,” the investor repeated, his tone firm.

Rob hesitated, glancing at his team. “Look, we’ve spent a lot of time and research on the plan we presented. We can’t just pull together something new on the spot.”

Suddenly, the second investor stood, his chair scraping loudly against the floor. “Are you insulting me?” he demanded, his voice rising. “Do you come into my office and show me such disrespect?”

Rob’s pulse quickened. “No, we’re not disrespecting you. We just can’t create a new business model right here and now.”

“This meeting is over!” the investor bellowed, storming toward the door. But as he reached for the handle, his silk tie caught in the heavy doorframe, jerking him backward. The room fell silent as the sound of tearing fabric echoed through the room.

The investor stood frozen for a moment, his face red with embarrassment. Slowly, he yanked at the torn tie, bits of silk fluttering to the floor as he exited without another word.

Rob stood in stunned silence; the air thick with disbelief. Then, a slow, dry chuckle came from one of the remaining investors.

“Well,” the man said, leaning back in his chair, “you certainly know how to make an impression.”

Rob tried to smile, but it came out forced. “So...”

The investor gave a short, amused laugh. “You definitely set the record for the most dramatic meeting we’ve ever had.”

Rob, swallowing his frustration, could only muster a weak smile. This was not how he had envisioned the day going.

Outside the elevator, the team gathered by a large window in the lobby, the tension between them palpable. Rob placed his briefcase down, his mind racing over every moment of the failed presentation.

Rick was the first to speak, his anger barely contained. “I don’t understand why you couldn’t just make something up, Rob.”

Rob stared at him, his own frustration building. “Like what?”

“Like one of the million ideas we’ve come up with! All we needed to do was buy time and come back to them later.”

Rob ran a hand through his hair, exasperated. “Don’t you believe in what we have?”

Rick scoffed. “It doesn’t matter what we believe. They’re the ones with the money, and you’ve basically pissed in the well.”

Stacy, watching the exchange, finally spoke up. “Money isn’t everything.”

Rick shot her a look. “Oh, sure. Then why don’t we ask your parents for a few million bucks?”

Stacy smiled slightly, a hint of bitterness in her voice. “Suddenly, a stick and water doesn’t seem so bad after all.”

Rick’s face turned red with embarrassment, realizing that Stacy had overheard them gossiping about her earlier.

“You’ve got to be kidding me,” Rick muttered, starting to turn away. “You really want to—”

“Relax,” Mike cut in, trying to diffuse the situation.

But Rick was already walking off. “It’s not like Rob’s reputation in Silicon Valley was stellar to begin with,” he said, his voice trailing off as he disappeared down the hallway.

Mike sighed, looking back at Rob. “He’ll come around.”

Rob stood there, staring after Rick, his shoulders slumped. “How come people can’t recognize innovation when they see it?”

Mike placed a hand on his shoulder. “Let me go talk to him.”

As Mike walked away, Rob found himself standing alone with Stacy. She stepped closer, her voice low and soft. “You didn’t blow anything, Rob,” she said, her eyes locking with his. “We have so much potential—you and I. We’ll have plenty of opportunities going forward. We just can’t let anyone come between us.”

Her words lingered in the air, laden with an intensity that Rob wasn’t sure how to interpret. She smiled, her gaze lingering a bit too long, then walked away, leaving him standing there, unsettled.

Chapter 7: The Investors' Meeting

The Ascend team sat scattered around the dining table in Rob and Terry's Oakland home, still feeling the sting of the disappointing KLVC meeting. Their faces were a mix of exhaustion and determination as they argued over how to refine their pitch.

Rob, standing by the window, absentmindedly stirring his tea, snapped back to reality when the phone rang. He glanced at the team, then crossed the room to answer it.

"Rob Ryan speaking."

"Rob, it's Tim Kinsley," came the familiar voice. Tim had been one of Rob's old contacts from his Intel days, now a venture capitalist with an eye for new tech.

"Tim, how are you?" Rob said, trying to sound casual but feeling the weight of the moment.

"I'm doing well. Heard you had a bit of an adventure with KLVC yesterday," Tim said, his tone knowing.

Rob chuckled, but it was forced. "Yeah, well, not every pitch is going to land."

"Well, word certainly got around," Tim replied. "But my team and I were intrigued by your grit. Look, I'm flying to Boston in a couple of hours, but I have some downtime at SFO. How about we meet at the Red-Carpet Lounge? You can give me your pitch."

Rob's eyes widened as the opportunity sunk in. "Yeah, I can make that work. Two hours?"

Tim confirmed, and Rob hung up. He turned to the team, his energy shifting in an instant.

"Alright, team. Tim Kinsley is waiting for us at the airport."

Rick looked up from the pile of papers he was sifting through, confusion etched on his face. "Who the hell is Tim Kinsley?"

Before Rob could answer, Terry interjected with a knowing smile. "He's someone who can change everything."

The drive to the airport was, in typical Ascend fashion, chaotic. Mike was in the passenger seat, checking over the pitch materials, while Stacy sat behind him, attempting to fix her hair. Rick sat squashed in the back, complaining incessantly.

"Mike, can you scoot over a little? Your legs are like giraffe legs. I can't breathe back here," Rick groaned, trying to find some space.

Mike glanced back, unimpressed. "Excuse me? I'm not the one who packed half of my office into this car."

"You're the problem. It's like sitting next to a tree," Rick muttered.

“Both of you, shut up!” Stacy snapped, rolling her eyes. “And for the love of God, let’s at least pretend we get along. They need to see that we’re a well-oiled machine.”

Rob, who had been laser-focused on the road, gripped the steering wheel tighter. “Guys, we can’t blow this one. Get it together.”

The bickering continued in the background, but Rob tried to tune it out, his mind already at the airport, imagining how the pitch would play out.

Rob and his team rushed into the Red-Carpet Lounge, where Tim Kinsley was waiting, calm and composed, flipping through some documents.

“So, Rob,” Tim said, raising an eyebrow, “before we start, can you explain something? What exactly didn’t KLVC get? What did they miss?”

Rob smirked, already pulling a piece of paper from the table. “Well, Tim, let me show you something.”

He folded the paper quickly into the shape of an airplane, holding it up for a moment. “Networking has changed repeatedly over the past 50 years,” Rob began. “The companies that took the risk—the ones that bought the expensive first-class tickets to the future—were the ones that led the revolution.”

With a flick of his wrist, Rob launched the paper airplane into the air. The room watched in silence as it flew across the lounge, gliding smoothly before it landed softly on the floor. Tim couldn’t help but chuckle.

“You see,” Rob continued, “KLVC? They buy economy-class tickets. They’re not ready for the next leap forward. But we are.”

Tim smiled, clearly entertained but also impressed by Rob’s unconventional approach.

“Alright, Rob. You’ve got my attention.”

Ninety minutes later, after an intense but successful pitch, Rob and his team were on their way back to the house. They piled into the dining room, Terry already preparing dinner in the background.

They had barely sat down to eat when the phone rang. Rob picked it up, his heart racing.

“Rob,” Tim’s voice boomed through the line, the sound of boarding calls echoing in the background. “I’ve got good news. We’re in.”

Rob blinked in disbelief. “Really? That’s fantastic.”

“Yeah but listen. We’ve got a lot of work ahead. I’m on board, but the rest of the team needs convincing. We’ll need a full presentation. Are you ready for that?”

Rob looked around at his team, who had perked up at the news, and smiled. “Tim, we’re more than ready.”

Two days later, the Ascend team was standing in front of a group of investors from **GrayRock Ventures**—a prominent tech investment firm. Rob and Stacy presented from the foam-core boards they had prepared, while Rick sat at the corner, scribbling down notes.

Midway through the presentation, one of the investors interrupted. “So, Rob, what happened with KLVC?”

Rob glanced over at Tim, who was seated in the back, giving him a reassuring nod. Without missing a beat, Rob responded, “I’m going to tell this story once, so there’s only one version, instead of a hundred.”

He paused for effect before continuing. “KLVC missed the revolution. We’re in the middle of a series of changes in networking, and only those with vision can see it. KLVC? They’re stuck in the past. We’re here to build the future.”

The room was quiet at first, the investors processing Rob’s bold statement. Then, a chuckle came from the back, quickly spreading as the room filled with laughter and applause. Tim flashed Rob a thumbs-up, signaling victory.

Rob finished the presentation with confidence, and this time, when he asked, “So, are you going to give us the money?” he already knew the answer.

Here’s the revised version of the investor showdown scene, incorporating Charles York's introduction as the antagonistic force while Tim remains supportive. This will help set up the future conflicts between Rob and Charles.

****

The meeting room was thick with tension as Rob Ryan stood before the gathered investors. Ascend had caught the attention of some of Silicon Valley’s biggest players, and now they were on the brink of securing a pivotal $3 million investment. Rob had handled tough investors before, but today was different. This meeting included Charles York—a man who carried a reputation for being both brilliant and merciless.

Tim Kinsley had brought Charles on board. Rob trusted Tim: they had a solid relationship dating back to their Intel days, and Tim had always been a supportive presence. But Charles? Rob wasn’t so sure. Charles had a history of taking control and pushing companies in directions that didn’t always align with the founders’ visions. Rob had heard the stories.

As Rob presented Ascend's strategy for their first product, Charles sat at the back, silently observing, his eyes sharp and calculating. Rob could feel the weight of Charles's scrutiny, even as Tim sat next to him, offering encouraging nods.

Rob had barely finished explaining how Ascend planned to break into the market when Charles leaned forward, breaking his silence.

"So, Rob," Charles began, his voice smooth but sharp, "how do you plan to create your first product?"

Rob kept his composure, offering a detailed response. This wasn't the first time he had been grilled by investors, and he knew how to handle pressure. But as soon as he finished, Charles turned his gaze to Mike.

"And how do *you* plan to create the first product?"

Mike hesitated, glancing at Rob before answering, mirroring much of what Rob had just explained. Charles listened carefully, then nodded, seemingly satisfied.

"That's great," Charles said, his smile never quite reaching his eyes. "Now, Rob, can you explain your ideation process?"

Rob felt a flash of irritation but kept it in check. He repeated part of the explanation he'd already given, hoping to move the conversation forward. But Charles wasn't done. As soon as Rob finished, Charles turned back to Mike with the same question.

Before Mike could open his mouth, Rob stepped forward, cutting through the tension with calm authority.

"We need a bathroom break," Rob announced, his voice firm but controlled.

Charles raised an eyebrow, clearly taken aback. "The facilities are down the hall," he said, his tone dismissive.

"No," Rob said, standing his ground. "Everyone needs a bathroom break. Let's take five. Everyone who isn't me or Charles, take a moment outside."

The room fell silent. The other investors exchanged uncertain glances, but Tim, sitting beside Charles, gave Rob a subtle nod of approval. One by one, the other members of the board stood and filed out of the room, leaving Rob and Charles alone.

As the door closed, Rob crossed the room and sat down directly across from Charles. He met Charles's gaze, his expression steady.

"Charles, I don't care whether you invest or not. If you like what Ascend is doing, we'd welcome you on board. If not, that's fine. But there's one thing I won't tolerate: disrespect. When I answer a question, it's answered. Am I clear?"

Charles regarded Rob for a long moment, his smile fading into a more serious expression. Then, to Rob's surprise, a small grin crept back onto Charles's face, this time more genuine.

“You’re clear,” Charles replied.

“Good,” Rob said, standing up. “Now, should my team and I leave, or are we going to continue this properly?”

Charles chuckled, leaning back in his chair. “I’d like you to continue. And don’t worry—I’ll be on my best behavior.”

Rob nodded, calling out to the others, “Alright, everyone, let’s get back to business.”

As the team re-entered the room, Rob could feel the shift in the dynamic. Charles might be a tough opponent, but Rob had set the tone. For now, they were on the same side. But something told Rob this wasn’t the last time he’d have to put Charles in his place.

A few days after the meeting, Ascend officially secured the $3 million investment. Tim had made it happen, but Charles was now part of the deal. He’d joined the board of Ascend alongside Tim, and while Tim remained a supportive ally, Charles was a different story. He watched everything Rob did with a scrutinizing eye, always pushing, always challenging. Rob knew that Charles wasn’t the type to sit quietly in the background.

Over the weeks and months to come, Charles would become a larger presence at Ascend—one that Rob couldn’t ignore. What had started as a simple investor relationship was slowly turning into something more adversarial. Tim was a friend, but Charles? Charles was a threat, whether Rob realized it fully yet or not.

Chapter 8: Facing the Wave

With the $3 million in funding secured, Ascend was ready to take off. But as the company grew, so did the challenges. Rob and his team had the vision, but it was Terry who took on the task of turning that vision into reality.

"I'm leaving my law practice," Terry told Rob one evening, her voice steady. "Ascend needs me, and I'm not going to watch from the sidelines."

Rob looked at her, conflicted. "Terry, you know I don't feel comfortable paying you. You're my wife. It wouldn't feel right."

Terry smiled softly. "I'll live with that. We're building something bigger here. I don't need a paycheck to know my worth."

And so, Terry threw herself into the work. She handled the logistical headaches—organizing the Oakland office, managing deliveries, and keeping everything running smoothly.

Rob's hiring approach was equally unorthodox. One day, as he sat across from a potential recruit, Tom, the conversation turned to compensation.

"How much are you expecting?" Rob asked, glancing at Tom's resume.

Tom hesitated before answering. "I was thinking around $200,000."

Rob smiled, shaking his head. "Yeah, that's not going to work because of the Post-It Rule."

Tom looked confused. "The what?"

Rob leaned back in his chair. "Here at Ascend, we're transparent about everything—salaries included. My salary is $80,000, and everyone knows it. If I gave you $200,000, I'd have to write it on a Post-It and stick it on your door. And trust me, that wouldn't sit well."

Tom blinked, unsure how to respond. Rob, sensing the tension, offered a solution. "Tell you what—let's have dinner. You, me, and your wife. I'll explain everything, and you both get a chance to ask me anything."

Here's a refined version of the paragraph with smoother flow and a bit more punch:

That evening, at a quiet restaurant, Rob laid it out plainly for Tom and his wife.

"I know this isn't the offer you were expecting," Rob said bluntly. "I'm offering $50,000. Tom's going to be working six days a week—late nights, weekends, everything. And the equity? It could end up being worthless. It's a gamble."

Tom's wife raised an eyebrow, clearly taken aback. "This sounds more like a warning than a job offer," she said with a laugh.

Rob smiled, unfazed. "It's honest. We're building something tough here, and it's not just the employees making sacrifices. My wife's fully involved without a paycheck, and we all need to be on the same page. Tom will need your support, too—because I'll need him 100% focused on this mission. I can't promise it'll pay off, but if it does, it'll be worth it."

Tom's wife paused, then smiled. "Alright," she said. "When does Tom start?"

As Terry worked tirelessly behind the scenes, Rob and his partners—especially Stacy—kept their focus on the bigger picture. But Stacy's strong personality was becoming a source of friction. She was brilliant, but also impulsive and often abrasive.

During one of their regular meetings, Stacy leaned back, swirling her wine. "I think I'd be better off starting my own company," she said casually. "I don't do well taking orders from people who are three steps behind me."

Rob smiled but sensed the tension. "You're not thinking of leaving us, are you?"

Stacy shrugged. "Not yet. But sometimes I feel like I could be doing more."

Terry, who had been sitting quietly, felt the weight of Stacy's words. The tension between them was unspoken, but it was there. Stacy had never liked that Terry, as Rob's wife, worked at Ascend without a formal title. But as Terry didn't get a salary made, while Rob's transparency on compensation was meant to keep things clear, it only fueled Stacy's frustrations.

It wasn't long before the tension reached a boiling point.

One day, Terry rounded the corner of the hallway near Rob's office and spotted Stacy pressing her ear against the wall, listening to a private conversation.

"Can you come with me for a sec?" Terry asked, grasping Stacy's elbow firmly.

Stacy jumped, caught off guard, but followed Terry down the hall without a word. Later, during a meeting with Rob, Stacy stormed into the room, her voice sharp.

"Rob, I don't understand why you have that guy in sales," she began. "What are you paying him for? He's useless!"

Rob glanced at Terry, then back at Stacy. "Stacy, you're in charge of engineering. Isn't that enough?"

Stacy's mouth tightened, her frustration clear. She spared a glare at Terry before spinning on her heel and walking out of the room.

For all the internal tensions, the real pressure came from the investors. At the next board meeting, Rob found himself standing before a stern group of faces. Charles York, as usual, sat with his arms crossed, a look of impatience etched on his face.

"Alright, Rob," Tim said, his tone encouraging. "We're all listening."

Rob took a deep breath. "We've reduced the communications protocol from 5,000 lines of code to 500."

Charles leaned forward, unimpressed. "But that doesn't make the product any more marketable, does it?"

"No," Rob admitted, "but we're getting close."

"Close?" Charles scoffed. "Businesses don't succeed on 'close.' They succeed when they nail it."

Rob glanced around the room, searching for a way to explain his vision. His eyes landed on a photograph of the beach hanging on the wall, and he grasped for an analogy.

"Has anyone here been to the beach?" Rob asked. "There are surfers who get up early, paddle out, and position themselves perfectly for the big wave. When it comes, they're ready."

Charles leaned back in his chair, smirking. "And what if the wave doesn't come?"

"It always comes," Rob replied. "Eventually."

Charles shook his head. "Rob, first it was a jet plane, now it's surfing. What's next? Turtle races?"

As the meeting ended, Tim patted Rob on the shoulder. "We need to show results," he said quietly.

Rob nodded, but inside, he knew the pressure was mounting.

Chapter 9: Riding the Wave

"There has to be a way forward," Rob said as he slumped into his home office chair, staring at the flickering lamp on his desk. His head was buzzing with ideas, but none of them seemed good enough. He ran through the numbers in his head, replaying the board's demands. Finally, an idea sparked. He grabbed the phone and dialed.

"Yes?" came Stacy's voice on the other end, her tone sharp. It was late, and she wasn't in the mood for small talk.

"Hey, it's me," Rob said, trying to sound casual. "You busy?"

"When am I not busy?" she replied, voice dripping with sarcasm. "But for you, I'll make an exception."

"I think I've got something," Rob said, his energy returning. "Video conferencing. We make it cheaper, better—get the costs down so companies can actually afford it."

"Go on," Stacy said, her interest piqued.

"It's too damn expensive right now. T-1 lines, ten grand a month. How do we lower that and improve the quality?" Rob was pacing now, ideas flowing.

Stacy was quick to respond. "Bandwidth on demand. Use low-speed analogs—"

Rob cut her off. "That might work outbound, but the return will get scrambled."

"Says who?" Stacy laughed. "The phone companies? They don't know anything."

Rob smiled despite himself. "You're incredible."

At that moment, Terry entered the kitchen in her nightgown, heading for a glass of water when she overheard Rob's last sweet words. "Hmm, I'm incredible? Am I dreaming… or are you drunk?"

Rob, who was focused on the call, didn't notice Terry's appearance. Meanwhile, on the other end of the line, Stacy's voice softened a little, taking on a playful edge. "You and I, Rob... we could be a real power couple."

Rob laughed, leaning back in his chair. "Yeah, we are a power couple."

"No, seriously," Stacy pressed. "We're making waves here, and with this—this could be it. We could really take things to the next level."

"You're something special, you know that?" Rob said softly.

Terry smiled to herself, her heart warming. She hadn't expected such a sweet compliment, especially so late at night.

She stepped into the room, a big smile on her face. "Thanks, honey. You're so sweet."

Rob turned, startled. He was still holding the phone. "Uh, Terry? What?"

Her smile faltered as she realized he wasn't talking to her. "Wait, who are you talking with?"

"Stacy," Rob said, lowering the phone. "I was running an idea by her."

"Stacy? At this hour?" Terry's voice sharpened. "It's almost midnight, Rob. You don't think that's a little... strange?"

Rob winced, trying to stay calm. "There's nothing going on between us if that's what you're implying."

Terry shook her head. "This isn't a normal employer-employee relationship, Rob."

She turned and left the room without another word.

Stacy, hearing the unexpected voices over the line, smiled to herself before hanging up. **"Hmm... finally, some trouble in the kingdom palace."**

Two weeks later, the board gathered as planned for another meeting, looking to hear Rob's solutions or, as Charles predicted, his excuses. The tension in the room was palpable. Charles York, grumbling under his breath, glanced at his watch every few minutes. Tim Kinsley sat beside him, trying to keep things light, but it wasn't working.

"Where's Rob?" Charles asked, his voice dripping with impatience.

"He'll be here," Mike said confidently.

One of the board members sat crunching loudly on a bag of chips, the sound echoing through the room. Charles shot him an irritated look. "Must you eat like that?" he barked.

The man, flustered, coughed, a chip getting stuck in his throat.

"Where is Rob?" Charles repeated, louder this time. "This is extremely unprofessional."

Stacy, fiddling with some monitors, glanced up. "Not exactly in the building."

"Not exactly?" Charles's face turned red. "That's it, I've had enough." He stood to leave, clearly fed up.

Before he could reach the door, Stacy hit a button on the monitor, and Rob's image appeared on the screen—fuzzy and barely audible.

"Hello, everyone!" Rob's voice crackled through the speakers.

Tim, visibly annoyed, leaned forward. "Rob, where are you?"

"Downtown," Rob replied with a grin. "Talking to you over a digital leased line that AT&T just installed. How's it coming across?"

"Terrible," Tim said flatly.

"Worse than terrible," Charles added.

"Okay, okay," Rob said, clearly enjoying himself. "Stacy, turn on the second monitor."

Stacy pressed a button, and Rob appeared again, this time crystal clear, his voice crisp.

"Me again," Rob said, now leaning into the camera with a smirk. "Only this time, I'm from the future. Notice the difference?"

The board members, intrigued, leaned forward.

"We call it Bandwidth on Demand," Rob continued. "This little box we've developed could make Ascend the king of video conferencing. High-quality video, low cost. We're talking a game changer."

Charles crossed his arms, skeptical. "And how exactly does this work?"

Rob gestured toward his watch. "Steve, zoom in on my watch, will you? Closer. All the way." The camera zoomed in until the details of Rob's watch were visible in sharp focus. "See both hands? Crystal clear. Who knows? Maybe in the future, dentists will be able to check your teeth for cavities remotely."

Charles rolled his eyes. "Are you serious?"

"Absolutely. The future is here, Charles," Rob replied with a grin.

Charles shifted in his seat, clearly annoyed but begrudgingly impressed. "So, what now?"

Rob leaned back, savoring the moment. "So, you're giving me the green light to ride this wave while the competition sticks to their turtle races?"

Charles glared at him but said nothing. Tim chuckled, unable to hide his amusement.

The board members exchanged glances, and finally, Tim spoke. "It's a good start, Rob. But remember, Ascend's clock is still ticking. We need results—yesterday."

Rob nodded. "I hear you loud and clear."

The meeting ended with a mix of frustration and hope. Rob had shown them something real, something that could change the game. But the pressure was still there—results, not just breakthroughs, were what the board cared about. And as Rob left the screen, he knew he wasn't just riding the wave. He was racing against time.

Chapter 10: Aftershocks

Ascend's revolutionary product had pushed the company forward. Video conferencing over phone lines was gaining traction, but Rob's relentless pursuit of perfection kept the team on edge. He was always demanding more, pushing for improvements at every turn.

The office hummed with activity, a constant flow of people and ideas. A young woman zipped through the halls on roller shoes, delivering mail as Rob stood at the center of the hardware lab, focused on a new piece of equipment.

"Is it protected?" Rob asked, his eyes scanning the device.

One of the hardware engineers looked puzzled. "Protected?"

Rob nodded, his voice firm. "It's not enough to design something for functionality. You've got to protect its sustainability too."

The team exchanged glances, unsure.

"I think we've covered all the vulnerabilities," another engineer said. "The frame has maximum protection."

Rob wasn't satisfied. "Alright, let's put it to the RQCC test."

The room quieted. "RQCC?"

Mike grinned. "Rob's famous Quality Control Check. Watch."

He gave the device a light tap on the table. Nothing happened.

"That's Mike's check," Rob said dryly. "Mine's a little different."

Without warning, Rob slammed the hardware onto the floor. The room shook, the lights flickered, and for a brief moment, it seemed like Rob's force had caused the commotion. Then the tremors continued, growing stronger.

"Earthquake!" one of the engineers shouted, panic setting in.

"Take cover!" Rob yelled, clutching his back in pain as he struggled to crouch.

Rick ran to his side. "Where's Terry?"

Rob, wincing in pain, forgot everything else. "Where is she?" His voice was frantic.

He pushed past the dust and debris, searching for Terry.

"Terry!" he shouted. "Terry!"

Amidst the chaos, Rob spotted Stacy. She reached out, trying to stop him. "Stay with me. Don't risk yourself!"

But Rob shoved her aside. "Let me go!" His focus was singular.

"Terry!" he called again.

Finally, Terry's voice came from under a desk. "Rob... I'm here."

Rob rushed to her side, pulling her out from beneath the debris. Relief washed over him as he hugged her tightly. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Terry whispered, still shaken.

Stacy watched from a distance, her eyes dark with envy. As Rob and Terry clung to each other, Stacy turned away, walking off into the chaos of the office.

The earthquake had left the office in shambles, but Rob's focus remained on the deadline.

"We've got to meet back here tonight," Rob said, rallying his team.

One of the engineers shook his head. "Tonight? Are you serious?"

Rob sighed. "Alright, we'll reconvene in the morning. Let's get out of here."

The broadcast station announced that most of the main roads and bridges were impassable. Stacy suggested they take a boat from a nearby marina to get home. As they carefully picked their way through the wreckage, Terry and Rob stayed close, exchanging nervous laughter, clinging to each other.

Stacy walked ahead of them, her mood darkening. When they reached the marina, Stacy climbed onto a boat but quickly realized she didn't have the key.

"Shit," Stacy muttered, searching her pockets. "The key isn't here."

As they started discussing alternative ways to get home, a familiar voice called out to Terry. It was a lawyer she knew, about to sail home on his boat. He offered them a ride, and Terry and Rob gladly accepted, but Stacy stayed quiet, her frustration simmering.

As the boat cut through the water, Terry sat back, feeling relief wash over her. Stacy stood at the bow, silent, watching the horizon as Rob and Terry stayed close together. It was clear to Stacy that Rob's connection with Terry remained strong, and she felt sidelined, isolated in her thoughts.

A few days later, Rob rushed toward the entrance, dressed in tennis clothes. Terry stood there, arms crossed, waiting for him.

"Why on earth were you playing tennis?" she demanded. "You're supposed to be in the meeting."

Rob frowned. "It wasn't in my calendar."

Terry's frustration boiled over. "I sent you an email, Rob."

"No, you didn't," Rob said, his tone sharp. "And this has been happening a lot lately."

Terry's eyes flashed with anger. "What are you saying?"

Rob looked at her coldly. "I can't just ignore this because you're my wife, Terry. Things are slipping through the cracks."

"I told you, I sent the email!" Terry shot back. "Back off!"

A small group of employees passed by, sensing the tension. Rob turned away, unwilling to continue the argument. "This is crazy," Terry muttered as he walked off.

In the conference room, Rob sat before a screen, Charles York and Tim Kinsley staring back at him with frustration.

"Rob," Tim said calmly, "the board's concerned."

Rob leaned back, exasperated. "Again? We've nearly taken control of the entire market."

Charles scoffed. "We're a big fish in a small pond."

Rob clenched his fists. "Our technology is going to connect people around the world."

Tim remained skeptical. "That sounds great, but it feels like we're headed for shutdown—or you're expecting everyone to communicate through screens all day."

"What if there's another earthquake? Or a war? Or a plague?" Rob fired back. "This technology is the future."

Charles shook his head. "The only plague I see is this company's stagnation. Nobody's making money."

Rob pressed his point. "If you understood my vision—"

Charles cut him off, glancing at his watch. "Rob, if video conferencing is your vision of the future, then this company has no future."

Tim stepped in. "We're out of time. Let's regroup in a week. And Rob—be on time."

The screen went blank, leaving Rob fuming.

At the same time, Terry was in her office, fuming over the argument with Rob. Something wasn't right, and she needed answers.

"Mike, can you look at my email box?" she asked. "I swear my emails aren't getting sent."

Mike sat down at her desk, typing quickly. After a few minutes, he frowned. "There's something off here."

"What do you mean?" Terry asked.

"Your emails aren't being sent. Someone's created a ghost email box. They're getting rerouted to nowhere."

Terry's face darkened. "Is this a mistake?"

Mike shook his head. "No. This was done deliberately."

Terry's mind raced, and one name came to her lips. "Stacy."

Rick, standing nearby, tried to calm her down. "Let's not jump to conclusions."

But Terry wasn't having it. "Who else could it be? She's the queen of computer programming!"

Mike hesitated but nodded. "It's possible."

"She's out of control!" Terry stormed out of her office, her frustration boiling over.

While Terry was seeking comfort and answers, she saw Stacy loitering near Rob's office door, a glass pressed against the wall, clearly eavesdropping on Rob's private conversation with the board members. Terry approached her quietly, watching as Stacy concentrated on listening in.

With a sudden smile, Terry grabbed Stacy's elbow hard. "Can you come with me for a sec?" she said sweetly, though her grip tightened.

Stacy, startled, looked up, but Terry didn't wait for an answer. She dragged Stacy down the hall, ignoring her protests.

In front of the team, Terry confronted her.

"Why are you sabotaging my work?" Terry demanded, her voice sharp with anger.

"What are you talking about?" Stacy answered, her voice laced with sarcasm.

"You know exactly what I'm talking about. You've been messing with my emails, undermining me."

Stacy smirked coldly. "Oh, Terry. You don't belong here. Everyone knows it."

Terry stepped closer, her voice low but furious. "This isn't your private company, Stacy. And I won't let you destroy what Rob and I built."

Stacy's eyes narrowed. "Let's see how long you last, then."

Terry's anger followed her throughout the day. She hoped the upcoming ride to the cabin with Rob would give her a chance to settle things once and for all.

Chapter 11: Breaking Point

Rob and Terry sat in their car, the familiar road to their cabin in Yosemite winding ahead of them. The tension was thick, hanging in the air like a storm about to break. Rob glanced over at Terry, who was staring out the window, her thoughts far away. After a long silence, Rob spoke up.

"Where's Stacy? She's not coming to the cabin?"

Terry's head snapped toward him; her expression incredulous. "Stacy? You're asking me about Stacy? She's not my guest, Rob. She's yours."

Rob frowned. "Mine? I never invited her. She told me you did."

Terry's eyes narrowed. "Me? I thought *you* invited her." She shook her head in disbelief. "I've had it up to here with her!" She gestured above her head. "She worms her way into our work life, and now she's trying to invade our personal life too?"

Rob's brow furrowed as he realized the manipulation that had been going on. "You really think she's playing us against each other?"

Terry sighed, her voice thick with frustration. "Of course she is. And you're letting her! Why do you keep bringing her into our lives? Even on a vacation, I can't get away from her. It's like she's everywhere."

Rob was silent, gripping the wheel tightly. The miles passed by, but the weight of the conversation lingered between them, unresolved.

Finally, Terry broke the silence. "You're not seriously thinking about keeping her on at Ascend, are you?"

Rob's jaw tightened, but he didn't answer.

"Rob!" Terry insisted, her voice rising.

"What do you want me to say, Terry?" Rob finally replied, his voice tired. "The situation between you and Stacy is unsustainable."

Terry's face hardened. "Exactly. She invaded my privacy, made me look incompetent. I feel like I'm back in high school, dealing with some bully." She paused, catching her breath. "Once, there was this girl who used to pick on me because of the color of my hair. And now here I am, dealing with it all over again."

Rob's tone was more restrained. "Okay, now you're being dramatic. It's a sensitive situation, Terry."

"It's only going to get worse!" Terry shot back. "Look, I know it'll be hard to work without her, but—"

"Can we just wait until we get to the cabin?" Rob interrupted, his voice tense.

"No," Terry snapped. "I'm tired of you dancing around the issue. If there's something you need to say, just say it."

Rob hesitated for a moment before blurting out, "I have to let you go, Terry."

A heavy silence fell over the car. Terry blinked, as if she hadn't heard him right. "What?"

Rob didn't respond.

"What did you just say?" Terry's voice trembled. "Pull over. Stop the car!"

"Terry—"

"Stop the car!" she screamed, reaching for the steering wheel. Rob swerved, struggling to keep control of the vehicle as they came to a screeching halt by the side of the road.

"Are you crazy?" Rob shouted.

Terry pushed the door open and got out, slamming it behind her as she began walking away from the car.

"Terry!" Rob called after her, exasperated.

Terry stormed ahead, her feet pounding against the gravel. "I quit my job for this?" she shouted back. "For you to just... replace me?"

Rob scrambled out of the car, jogging to catch up with her. "Look, it's my company. People rely on me. I have no choice."

Terry stopped, spinning around to face him. "No choice? Really? You have a gun to your head?"

Rob threw his hands in the air. "Pretty much, yeah! And when I make decisions about Ascend, I can't be your husband—I'm the CEO. And frankly, Stacy is my ace."

Terry's eyes blazed. "Oh, so what am I? Your two of clubs?"

Rob looked pained. "No, you're... replaceable."

Terry froze, the word echoing in her mind. "Replaceable? You want her to replace me?"

She turned and started walking again, tears stinging her eyes.

"Terry, wait! That's not what I meant," Rob called after her. "Look, if I let her go, the company is going to fall apart. Everything I've worked for will go down the drain."

Terry stopped, her voice shaking. "And what about everything *I've* worked for? Or are we not enough of a 'power couple' for you?"

A long, heavy silence followed.

Rob exhaled. "I'm just doing what's best for the company. It's business, Terry."

Terry shook her head, her voice thick with emotion. "Monkey business. That's what it is."

She turned and continued walking, but Rob wasn't ready to let her go.

"Terry, listen! You're a great lawyer. I thought I could get you out of the office so you could focus on what you love. You could do it from home."

Terry stopped again, her voice bitter. "And what about everything else I do?"

"Julia, who worked for us, is coming back. She can handle things, and you can manage her by telecom. What do you say?"

Terry stood there for a moment, her anger simmering just beneath the surface. "I'll think about it," she muttered.

With a deep breath, Terry turned and walked back toward the car. Rob followed, the silence between them as heavy as the words they had exchanged.

Back in the car, Terry stared out the window, her thoughts swirling.

Rob tried to break the tension. "Maybe we can take a nice walk once we get to the cabin," he suggested, his voice tentative. "What do you think, Terry?"

Without looking at him, Terry answered coldly. "Why don't you invite my replacement to join you?"

Rob said nothing, the weight of the situation finally sinking in.

They arrived at the cabin, the silence between them as they got out of the car was deafening. Terry slammed the door shut and walked inside without a word, leaving Rob standing alone outside, feeling the full impact of the decision he had made.

Chapter 12: Seeds of Realization

Rob hiked through the dense forest, towering trees rising high around him. His steps were quick, almost frantic, as he climbed the familiar trail toward the summit. The weight of the board's unsatisfaction from the situation and the tension with Terry were too heavy for him. Each step felt like an attempt to outrun the storm brewing inside him.

Reaching the top of the mountain should have brought relief, but there was no peace here. The vast expanse of the valley below was indifferent to his struggle.

Suddenly, his satellite phone rang, its shrill tone cutting through the stillness. Rob flinched.

"Jesus…" he muttered, fumbling through his bag. "Rob here."

The voice on the other end crackled with static. "Rob, it's Tim."

Rob pressed the phone closer to his ear. "Tim? You're breaking up."

"The board's decided to sell Ascend!" Tim's voice came through louder, but still distorted.

Rob felt a surge of panic. "What are you talking about?"

"Some video company just put in an offer—35 million."

"That's a fraction of its value!" Rob snapped. "We the engineers will walk away with nothing! While you and Charles will make money"

Static buzzed in his ear. "Hello?"

"Tim?" Rob's frustration boiled over. "Goddammit!"

The line went dead. Rob cursed, looking around for a better signal. He started climbing higher, desperate to reconnect.

Finally, at a small clearing, the signal returned. "Tim! Can you hear me now?"

Tim's voice was faint but clear. "I'm sorry, Rob. Charles pushed the board to sell. I voted against it, but I was in the minority."

Rob's chest tightened. "Listen to me! There's something we can still do."

"There's nothing I can do," Tim replied, defeated.

"There is!" Rob insisted. "Tell Charles that without me and the engineers, Ascend is an empty shell. The buyer needs to know that, and I don't think they'll want the company if they're losing the core team."

Tim hesitated. "Rob, are you threatening us?"

"No! It's not a threat, it's a fact!" Rob's voice grew more desperate, but before he could say more, the line cut off again.

“Tim? Tim!” Rob yelled at the phone. Furious, he hurled it at a nearby tree, the device bouncing off the bark and landing in the dirt.

“They can’t do this to me… THEY CAN’T DO THIS TO ME!”

His rage overtook him. Rob bolted down the trail, his feet pounding against the earth, dodging branches and leaping over rocks. His mind raced, consumed by the thought of losing everything he had built. He ran faster and faster, trying to outrun the fear, the frustration, the helplessness.

Then, suddenly, his foot caught on a log. Rob tumbled down a small ravine, his body rolling over rocks and roots. He felt a sharp pain as his head hit the ground, and everything went black.

When Rob came to, the world around him seemed different. He blinked, trying to focus through the haze. Above him, golden petals swayed gently in the breeze—sunflowers. A whole field of them stretched out before him, their faces turned toward the sun, following its path across the sky. He groaned and sat up, wincing as he touched the small cut on his forehead.

A normal person would be amazed by the view… but Rob’s mind worked differently, always searching for patterns, structures, and mathematical puzzles. His thoughts connected the dots—Tim’s call, the board’s decision, Charles’s push to sell Ascend. His chest tightened, but then his gaze drifted back to the flowers, and something stirred inside him.

Suddenly, the rumble of an ATV engine broke his thoughts. He turned to see a farmer driving toward him on a small vehicle, towing a trailer behind. The farmer stopped when he saw Rob sitting among the sunflowers.

“You alright there, mister?” the farmer called, switching off the engine.

Rob stood, brushing dirt off his clothes. “Yeah, just a bit disoriented. Took a bit of a fall.”

The farmer chuckled. “Looks like you landed in the best spot—my sunflower field.”

Rob looked around again, taking in the sea of golden flowers. “It’s... it’s incredible.”

The farmer gave a broad grin. “Yup. Sunflowers are something special. People think I’m crazy for growing so many, but there’s a lot more to ‘em than meets the eye.”

Rob couldn’t help but smile. “You a fan of Van Gogh?”

The farmer scratched his head, confused. “Van who?”

“Van Gogh,” Rob repeated.

The farmer squinted, then grinned. “I dunno what team he plays for, but I’m more of a baseball fan.”

Rob laughed, shaking his head. “Never mind.”

The farmer climbed off the ATV and walked closer. “But you know, these flowers—there’s something special about ‘em. I ain’t no scientist or nothing, but I heard they’ve got some kind of magic. Something to do with the way they’re built—spirals and stuff. Grows like that for a reason. Heard it’s the same way galaxies are arranged, or something about how our bodies work too. Crazy, huh?”

Rob’s mind whirred, processing the farmer’s simple wisdom. “Spirals... yeah, the Fibonacci sequence. The structure is perfect. It’s... it’s all about maximizing space, growth, survival.”

The farmer picked one of the sunflowers, pointing at the intricate spiral of seeds. "The way these seeds are arranged makes the flower grow better, more efficiently. It’s like the flower’s core identity—its gift from nature. Sometimes, I think we humans have our own kind of seeds inside us. If we understand them and use them right, we can flourish too. But most people miss it. Do you use your seeds well?"

The farmer stopped his philosophical musings, looking at Rob, whose eyes were shining with realization.

“You’re an amazing analyst,” Rob said, smiling. “Maybe you should be using your seeds in a better job.”

“I’ve got the best job in the world,” the farmer shot back. “My father taught me an important lesson: Use your seeds wisely. Do what aligns with your identity, your core strength. Make the most of your skills, passions, and resources. That’s why they call me the King of Sunflowers around here—I get the biggest harvest.”

“Wow,” Rob responded, impressed. This farmer was smarter than he’d expected. As the pieces of the puzzle began to fall into place, Rob stood there, the ideas of identity, core, and seeds buzzing in his mind.

“You want a ride to your car?” the farmer asked, snapping Rob out of his thoughts.

“Yes, please. I need to get back to civilization,” Rob replied.

“Don’t worry, I’ll take you. Hop on!”

Rob was about to climb onto the back when he noticed the name on the vehicle. “Honda makes ATVs?” he asked.

“If it’s got an engine, Honda makes it.”

“Hah?”

“That’s their core—that’s what they sow. Everything else just grows out of that.”

Rob’s eyes widened. “Engines... that’s their seed. That’s their core.”

“Yep. Everything else is just the byproduct,” the farmer said simply, as they drove to Rob’s car.

Terry stood at the cabin kitchen counter, arms crossed, still clearly frustrated from their earlier argument. She didn't turn around as Rob entered.

Rob hesitated by the door, unsure how to begin. Finally, he sighed. "Terry... I need to tell you something."

Terry turned, her eyes narrowing. "What now?"

He stepped closer, his face serious. "The board... they're trying to sell Ascend."

Terry froze, her anger suddenly replaced with concern. "What? Sell Ascend? What are you talking about?"

Rob sat down at the table, running a hand through his hair. "Charles is pushing it. Tim called me earlier. There's an offer on the table for 35 million."

"Thirty-five million?" Terry repeated, her voice rising. "That's nothing! Why would they even consider that?"

Rob shook his head, frustration clear in his eyes. "Because Charles wants to cash in, leaving me with nothing. He's never forgotten our first meeting—it's revenge. He's convinced the board that selling is the best option."

Terry sat down across from him, her earlier anger forgotten. "So, they'll double their money and leave you and the team with nothing? What are we going to do?"

Rob stared at the floor, his mind buzzing. "I have an idea," he said quietly. "Something I realized today, in the sunflower field."

Terry leaned forward, frowning. "Sunflower? What are you talking about?"

Rob glanced up at her, a hint of a smile playing at his lips. "The sunflower seeds."

Terry blinked, confused. "Rob, what are you saying?"

"I'll explain later," Rob said, his voice distant as he stared out the window. "But I think I've figured out how we can save Ascend—by using our seeds efficiently."

Terry watched him closely, her concern growing. "Are you okay? You're not... losing it, are you?"

Rob laughed softly, shaking his head. "No, Terry. I'm not losing it. I think... I'm finally starting to see things clearly. These are the seeds of our new journey."

Terry didn't fully understand what Rob was talking about, but she could see the determination in his eyes. She reached across the table, taking his hand. "Alright. But whatever it is, we'll figure it out together."

Rob nodded, feeling a strange calm settle over him. The pieces were coming together, and for the first time in a long while, he felt like he was on the right path. More than that, he felt an immense relief, knowing that Terry, despite everything, was standing by him. Her willingness to push aside

the anger and support him gave him the strength he needed. He wasn't alone. It was the push he needed to keep fighting for the future of Ascend.

At the same time, Charles York and Tim Kinsley sat at a corner table in an upscale restaurant, their conversation heavy with tension. Charles stirred his drink, his sharp eyes scanning the room. Tim leaned forward, his face set with frustration.

"You can't just force this sale through, Charles," Tim said. "Rob and the team are the heart of Ascend. Without them, what's left? The buyers won't make the deal."

Charles smirked, stirring his drink lazily. "The offer's on the table. Thirty-five million. We'll double our money. Not bad, right? You've seen the numbers—Ascend is stagnating. Rob's idealism is dragging the company down."

Tim shot back, "You've been after Rob since day one, haven't you? But without him and the engineers, Ascend is just an empty shell."

Charles's smirk faltered. He knew Tim was right. Rob had threatened to walk away, and that threat carried weight. The engineers would follow Rob, leaving Ascend without its innovation engine. The sale would collapse without them. Charles drummed his fingers on the table, his expression shifting from arrogance to calculation. He didn't like being cornered, but he also knew Tim was offering a way to avoid disaster.

"You're suggesting we just let Rob keep running things indefinitely?" Charles asked, skeptical.

Tim shook his head. "No. I'm suggesting a deal. Give him time to fix the problems. If he doesn't deliver, we move ahead with the sale. Three months."

Charles scoffed. "Three months? You're dreaming, Tim. The buyers won't wait that long."

Tim leaned back, exhaling slowly. "Then... three weeks? That's all I ask."

Chapter 13: The Seeds of Innovation

"Three weeks?" Stacy scoffed, her voice cutting through the room. "Have they lost their minds?"

The team sat around the conference table at Ascend's offices, the air thick with tension. Rob stood in front of the whiteboard, the fresh scratch on his forehead a reminder of his recent encounter in the forest. Across from him, Stacy, Mike, and Rick waited, each wearing a mix of curiosity and skepticism.

"Yes," Rob replied, a determined glint in his eyes. "Three weeks, 21 days... 505 hours... 30,240 minutes. But I think we can do it."

Mike snorted, leaning back in his chair. "Who do you think you are, Houdini?"

"Magic has nothing to do with it," Rob said, shaking his head. "I figured it out."

Rick raised an eyebrow. "Figured what out?"

Rob picked up a marker and drew a large sunflower on the board. He wrote in the center of the flower the word *Honda*. The petals of the flower extended outward, blank for now. He turned back to the team. "What do you think of when you hear the word *Honda*?"

The engineers exchanged confused glances.

"Cars?" Stacy ventured; her tone still unimpressed.

"Yes, cars," Rob agreed, writing the word *Cars* on one of the sunflower's petals. "But what else?"

"Honda also makes planes," Mike added, sarcasm creeping into his voice.

Rob didn't miss a beat. He wrote "Planes" on another petal.

"Motorcycles," Rick offered, leaning forward slightly, trying to follow Rob's thinking.

"Exactly," Rob said, jotting it down. "And ATVs." He added it to another petal, then turned back to face the team. "Do you know how many products Honda makes?"

The room was silent.

"Forty-seven," Rob said, pointing to the number he had written on one of the petals. "Forty-seven different products, all tied to one core strength. Do you know what that strength is? What are those seeds that allow Honda to grow so many petals?"

The team looked at him, still unsure.

"Engines," Rob said. "Engines are Honda's core competency. Everything else—the cars, the planes, the motorcycles—those are petals. They grow out of that core strength. It's their seed."

Rob paused, letting the idea sink in. "Now I ask you, what is Ascend's core? What are we the kings of? What's our seed?"

Mike crossed his arms, still skeptical but now intrigued. "I'd say 'Any-to-Any Communication' is definitely our seed."

"Exactly," Rob said, writing *Any-to-Any Communication* in the center of the sunflower and drawing a crown above the word *Ascend*. "We are the kings of data communication."

Stacy frowned, but her interest was piqued. "So, what are our petals?"

Rob began filling in the petals with the team's past achievements. "Ethernet," he said, writing it on one petal. "I structured the standard for it."

"ISDN," Rick added, and Rob wrote it down as well.

"Video conferencing," Mike suggested.

"Exactly," Rob said, jotting it down. "Video conferencing is our current petal, but the board thinks it's a limited market. They believe we've hit a ceiling. They're looking for a billion-dollar idea."

He paused, drawing a question mark on one of the remaining petals.

"A billion-dollar petal?" Mike said, half to himself.

"If you can dream it, you can do it," Rob said with a grin. "That's not even mine—Disney said that. He was the king of entertainment, and he proved it. His core competency was storytelling. His petals grew out of that: animation, feature films, amusement parks, toys, gadgets… And just like Disney, this isn't a one-man show. It's about the team—about using their skills, passions, and resources."

Mike leaned forward. "I get it. That's what we need to figure out."

Rob nodded, pacing now. "Exactly. Honda's seed was their engines. Disney's was storytelling. Ours is data communication. So, what's our next petal?"

Rick frowned. "So, what's our next move?"

Rob smiled. "First, let's grab something to eat and take a break. Then, we'll figure out which petal we need to grow next."

Later, at a nearby fast-food joint, the team sat at a corner table, sketching ideas on napkins. Rob sat with a burger in hand, but his mind was still on the boardroom.

"This billion-dollar petal," Mike said between bites of fries, "is going to come from what we already know."

Rob smiled, scribbling something down on a napkin. "Exactly. We don't need to reinvent the wheel. We need to find the biggest vulnerability in the digital communication market."

Rick, always the joker, grabbed a Burger King crown and placed it on his own head. "Well, right now, I'm the king of... endless questions."

"We just need to figure out what the digital communication market really needs," Mike said, wiping his hands on a napkin. "And then build the solution."

Rob nodded. "We'll start by making a list of all potential services or products that we can solve and build."

"And how exactly are we going to choose the winning petal?" Stacy asked.

"With the sunflower code," Rob replied confidently. "We'll use a set of criteria to rank each idea—value, uniqueness, leverage—and the winner will stand out. Then... we build it."

Back in the office, the team gathered around the whiteboard once more. Rob stood in front of the giant sunflower, now filled with potential ideas for products and services.

"Value, Uniqueness, Leverage," Rob wrote at the top of the board. "Every new idea needs to be measured by these three criteria. How much value does it bring to the customer? How unique is it? And how much can the customer leverage it for other products and services?"

The team started shouting out ideas, their voices overlapping in excitement. Each member gave a score for the potential of each idea. At the end of the process, they calculated the total score, and one idea stood out from the rest. With a bold stroke of red, Rob circled the clear winner.

"And the winner is... the 'WWW'," Rob announced.

Stacy leaned back in her chair, shaking her head in disbelief. "The web? Really? That's what we've come up with? This is bullshit."

Rob stayed calm. "But it got the highest score."

Stacy scoffed. "We're supposed to be looking for something substantial. The web's for a few geeks trying to play lousy video games."

"Actually," Mike cut in, "the *Wall Street Journal* recently reported there are already about 25 million people online worldwide."

"And over thirty thousand web pages," Rick added. "They're estimating it'll quadruple by the end of next year."

"Estimated," Stacy said, unimpressed. "That's just a fancy word for wishful thinking."

"Think of the possibilities," Rob said, leaning in. "If people were better connected, they could work from home instead of having to go to the office."

"They can buy goods by computer instead of driving to the store," he added.

Stacy rolled her eyes. "Great. So we're going to turn people into apocalyptic zombie robots."

"No," Rick said, smirking. "Online newspapers."

"Medical check-ups," Mike added.

"Porn," Rick said, deadpan.

The team all turned to look at him.

"I'm just saying," Rick shrugged.

"The internet today is so limited," Rob said, bringing the conversation back.

"And lame," Rick added with a laugh.

"Yeah, sputtering at best," Mike agreed.

"But if we could alleviate the bottleneck," Rob continued, "the potential could be limitless."

"And it fits perfectly with our experience—moving large volumes of data through tiny wires," Mike added.

Rob nodded. "Right. So all we need to do is find the web's biggest vulnerability."

"We could call internet providers, see what's bugging them," Stacy offered.

"That's a great idea!" Rob said, his energy surging. "We'll let the customer tell us what they need, and we'll respond with the right innovative solution."

Then, in a moment of inspiration, Rick grabbed the Yellow Pages. "Look at this," he said, sliding his finger down the page. "There are over 250 internet service providers listed here. What if that's our market?"

Rob paused, looking over Rick's shoulder. "That could be it. Now we just need to figure out what they need."

Want me to start making calls?"

Rob shook his head, smiling. "Not good enough. We're going to enter the lion's den—step into their world. Walk, drive, fly—whatever it takes. We will make a real walk about. We'll meet them all personally, face to face."

The team stood, their energy palpable. They were ready to hit the road and begin their journey to find the next petal that would save Ascend.

Got it! Here's the revised version with your adjustments:

That evening, Rob came home and collapsed into a chair, a blend of exhaustion and excitement in his voice. "Big changes at Ascend," he said. "I'm heading out for a few days of meetings across the country."

Terry, always perceptive, looked at him curiously. "Big changes? What's going on now? Where are you off to?"

Rob leaned forward, his eyes brightening with energy. "The team believes we can really help these ISPs. We're heading out to meet them face-to-face. We think this is going to be the game-changer. When Charles and the rest of the board see what we're about to pull off, they're going to be speechless."

Terry frowned slightly. "But we've always been a video company, Rob. Now we're data solution providers? Feels like we're losing our direction."

Rob shook his head, his tone calm but firm. "No, Terry, we're not losing our way—we're expanding. This is the whole point of the sunflower code. Video was just one petal. Everything we do is about data routing—that's our core. Whether it's video, text, or whatever comes next, it's all the same. The world's finally will start to see that." He stood up and smiled. "Can you help me pack my suitcase?"

Chapter 14: The Internet Gamble

The team scattered across the country, each tasked with a simple mission: figure out what was wrong with the internet and what it needed to survive. It didn't matter if the client was running a major ISP or a small, dusty basement operation—everyone's voice needed to be heard.

As the days passed, the answers were depressingly similar: frustration, disappointment, and mounting despair. ISPs were overcharging for a broken system that barely worked. The internet, once hailed as the future, was now teetering on the edge of collapse, with no one sure how to fix it. One evening, after another long day of meetings, Rob collapsed into his hotel bed, exhausted. Just as he closed his eyes, his phone buzzed on the nightstand. He glanced at the screen: it was Tim.

"Hey, Tim," Rob answered, his voice weary.

"Rob, we've got a situation," Tim began. "The board... well, it's come to their attention that Terry's no longer with Ascend."

Rob sighed, already sensing where this was headed. "Yeah, I had to let her go. It wasn't easy, but it was the right call."

"That's not the issue," Tim said carefully. "Charles, as usual, is looking for an angle. He's asking questions about her compensation. Wants to know what severance package she's getting."

Rob sat up in bed, the tension creeping into his shoulders. "Severance? Tim, she wasn't getting paid. No salary. No equity. Nothing."

There was a pause on the other end. Then Tim spoke again, his tone more serious. "Rob, I need to prep you. Charles is about to join this call. He's sniffing around, trying to find something—anything. He suspects you might've funneled money to Terry through the company. I know it's nonsense, but he's going to push."

Rob clenched his jaw. "Let him try."

"I'm looping him in now," Tim said.

A moment later, Charles' voice came through the speaker, smooth and calculated. "Rob, hope I'm not interrupting anything important."

"Just wrapping up another long day on the road, Charles. What can I do for you?" Rob replied, keeping his voice calm.

"Well, I'll cut to the chase," Charles said, his tone oozing suspicion. "It's come to my attention that Terry's no longer with Ascend. We need to ensure everything's above board with her departure. Compensation, severance, equity—you understand."

Rob leaned back against the headboard. "Charles, there's nothing to worry about. Terry never received a salary. No equity either."

There was a moment of silence, and then Charles spoke again, clearly caught off guard. “No salary? No equity? You mean to tell me she worked for free?”

“That’s right,” Rob said firmly. “She helped out because she believed in what we were building. But no money ever changed hands.”

Tim jumped in, sensing the tension. “Look, this is a delicate situation. Terry contributed a lot in the early days, and we need to acknowledge that. I suggest we offer her 30,000 fully vested shares as compensation. It’s only fair.”

Charles, realizing there was no scandal to uncover, hesitated. He had been hoping to catch Rob in something, but now he was cornered. He let out a resigned sigh. “Fine. Thirty thousand shares it is.”

Rob couldn’t help but smile to himself. Charles had come looking for trouble and had ended up agreeing to a generous deal for Terry. Once again, Rob had managed to turn the situation in his favor.

“Thanks, Charles,” Rob said, barely able to hide the satisfaction in his voice. “I’m glad we could resolve this.”

The call ended, and Rob leaned back, the weight of the conversation lifting off his shoulders. He had won this round.

The next morning, feeling a renewed sense of purpose, Rob stood in front of a run-down office. He knocked on the door, and after a moment, a heavyset man in his thirties opened it. He had the suspicious look of someone who’s been burned before.

“Mark Lopez?” Rob asked.

“Who wants to know?” the man replied, eyeing Rob with caution.

“I’m Rob Ryan. We spoke on the phone?”

Mark’s face relaxed. “Oh, right. Ascend. Come in.”

The inside of Mark’s office was a disaster zone. Papers, boxes, and wires were scattered everywhere. The room buzzed and blinked with the sound of modems struggling to keep up with the demands of the few customers Mark managed to serve. The place looked like a battlefield, with the internet as the losing side.

“Welcome to my kingdom,” Mark said with a sardonic smile.

Rob surveyed the chaos. “What the… this is like the tower of Babel.”

Mark chuckled grimly. “Yeah. Each one of these modems has its own protocol, and none of them can communicate with each other.”

Rob winced. “That’s… pretty inefficient.”

“And the costs are killing me!” Mark added, throwing his hands up in frustration. “I charge $40 a month per customer, but the phone company bills me $90, plus tax. It’s a total loss.”

Rob’s eyebrows shot up. “So how do you stay in business?”

Mark leaned back, his expression turning bitter. “Everyone’s doing it. AOL’s selling more subscriptions than they can handle. But no one’s making money.”

Rob sat down across from Mark. "Even AOL?"

"Even AOL," Mark confirmed. "The whole internet thing’s going down. It’s history. Zero. Nada."

Rob leaned forward, serious now. "What’s the biggest dilemma you’re facing in your business?"

Mark sighed. "Money. We’re paying taxes on every data connection like it’s a phone call, and it’s eating into our bottom line. We can’t serve all the customers we already have, and if we try to add more, we’ll drown. People are getting frustrated, and some are threatening lawsuits for breach of service."

Rob nodded. "Why haven’t you gone to a bigger company like Cisco for help?"

Mark scoffed. "We did. Told them everything—our costs, our angry customers, how we’re on the verge of collapse. You know what they did? Nothing. They didn’t do a damn thing. The Ciscos of the world don’t care about little ISPs like us. Without better data routing technology, there’s no future for the internet. It’ll just collapse."

Rob listened carefully, taking in the weight of Mark’s words. "So, what made you agree to meet with us, then?"

Mark shrugged. "I figured a smaller company like Ascend might actually care. You have skin in the game, just like us. The big players couldn’t care less if we go under, but I believe you might actually help us stay afloat."

Rob smiled. "You’re right. Ascend was built to serve companies like yours. And if we don’t innovate, we’ll be in the same boat."

Mark looked at him, hopeful but cautious. "What are you offering, then?"

Rob grabbed a napkin and sketched a simple box. “Imagine this: I build you a slim new device—one box that replaces ten of your monster modems. This box will handle 96 calls simultaneously, reducing your infrastructure and costs by half.”

Mark glanced at the napkin. “What you’re describing is my wet dream. But that doesn’t exist. And I ain’t paying for something that doesn’t exist.”

Rob smiled. “I’m not asking you to pay. I just need a commitment—a check. Something I can show my board to prove there’s demand.”

Mark narrowed his eyes. “Why should I trust you?”

Rob reached into his pocket and pulled out his own checkbook. “I’ll write you a personal check for double the amount. You can cash it if we cash yours. Ball’s in your court.”

Mark stared at Rob for a long moment, weighing his options. The phone in the background rang again, its incessant tone a reminder of the constant problems plaguing his operation.

Finally, Mark sighed and nodded. “You’ve got yourself a deal.”

Back in Rob’s office, Stacy, Rick, and Mike sat around the speakerphone, listening as Rob updated them.

“We all got the same answers across the board,” Rob said.

Mike laughed. “It was like taking candy from a baby.”

“This whole industry’s on the verge of collapse,” Rick added, shaking his head.

“All these tech giants are treating it like a fad,” Stacy said. “But it’s a data routing problem. And we can solve it.”

Mike nodded. “Like we did with video conferencing.”

“That’s the beauty of it,” Stacy continued. “Data is data.”

Rob’s voice came through the speaker, firm and resolute. “So, we all agree. The internet is our ace.”

Everyone in the room nodded. The internet wasn’t just a problem—it was their opportunity.

The next day, Rob entered the boardroom, carrying a large pizza box. The members of the board looked up, surprised by his entrance.

“Somebody order a pizza?” Rob grinned as he placed the box on the table.

Charles York, as always, was unimpressed. “What’s this about, Rob?”

Rob opened the pizza box, revealing several checks stacked neatly inside. He picked up the first one and handed it to the closest board member.

“What you’re holding in your hands,” Rob said, “are just a few checks given to me during our walkabout.”

Charles raised an eyebrow. “For what?”

Rob pulled out the napkin he'd drawn on during his meeting with Mark and passed it around. "For offering them a new box—one that replaces their modems and allows fewer lines to serve more customers, lowering the cost for internet service providers."

"How?" Charles asked, still skeptical.

"This box will handle 96 calls and sells for $50,000. That's exactly half of what internet service providers are paying now."

Charles folded his arms. "And what's the cost to us?"

"Six thousand to build," Rob replied. "That's a margin of $44,000 per unit."

The board members exchanged looks. The numbers were hard to argue with.

"But nobody writes a check for a sketch of something that doesn't exist," Charles said, his voice dripping with doubt.

"Well," Rob said, holding up the checks, "they just did. This technology will sell itself."

Tim, another board member, leaned forward. "And we have the know-how to build this?"

Rob nodded. "It's what we do. It's our core competency."

Charles narrowed his eyes. "How big is the market?"

Rob's face lit up with a smile. "You want a number? Alright, let me think… five billion people. Give or take a few."

Charles scoffed. "Science fiction."

Rob grinned wider. "That's my favorite kind of movie. And soon, people will be able to transfer pictures, and later, even video! Why go to a movie theater when you can watch it at home? And while you're at it, why not order a pepperoni pizza and have it delivered without even picking up the phone?"

The boardroom fell silent.

Tim broke the tension. "You're sure this is the future?"

Rob nodded confidently. "This, gentlemen, is Ascend's engine to create the future. And with your permission, I'd like to proceed."

One by one, the board members nodded their approval—except for Charles, who hesitated, his mind still calculating. Finally, after a long pause, he reluctantly gave a nod.

"Okay," Charles said with a sigh. "Show me what you've got."

Chapter 15: Ascend's Rise

Rob sat at his desk, scanning a stack of brochures presented to him by the marketing manager. Bold, clear headings flashed across the top of each page: "Double Speed!" "Maximum Bandwidth!" "More Users on One Line!" "High Efficiency, Zero Faults!" The Ascend logo adorned every page, and the products they showcased were becoming the backbone of modem rooms around the world.

But not everyone was really getting the power of that moment, embracing the changes with open arms. Jeniffer, one of the heads of the marketing team, voiced her frustration. "We're a video company, Rob. Now suddenly we're shifting to ISPs? This isn't what I signed up for." Others in the team shared her sentiment, and a few of them, including Jeniffer, decided to jump ship. Rob regretted seeing them go, but there was no time to dwell on it. The fax machine continued to churn out orders, piling up faster than they could fulfill. "Anyone who can't see where the future is headed is welcome to stay behind," Rob thought, as he kept his eyes firmly on the horizon, where new opportunities were waiting to be seized. The internet was transforming rapidly and Ascend was at the heart of it all.

In respective look this may be considered as the second eureka moment. The moment that changed the face of the internet and sparked a revolution in human life.

Rob leaned back in his chair, allowing the weight of that realization to settle in. Ascend wasn't just another tech company anymore—it had become the force that saved the internet from falling into obscurity. The products they developed were propelling the internet forward at a lightning pace, changing the way people lived, worked, connected, and thought. Every internet service provider in the world needed what Ascend was offering, and their sales were skyrocketing.

Rob's phone buzzed, and a smile spread across his face as he glanced at the caller ID—Mark Lopez, the small internet provider he'd helped just a few weeks ago.

"Mark!" Rob greeted warmly. "How's the new equipment treating you?"

"It's a lifesaver, Rob," Mark replied enthusiastically. "Honestly, I couldn't have imagined how smoothly everything's running now. I owe you big time."

"Well, don't thank me just yet," Rob chuckled. "I might need your help again soon." He hung up, still smiling, and left his office for his regular walk-through of the production and packaging lines. Rob was never the type of executive to sit in a fancy office wearing a suit and tie. He believed in staying involved and accessible to everyone. With Rob, it wasn't about waiting for people to come to him—he brought the mountain to Muhammad. He made a point to visit workers in every corner of the company, engaging them in direct conversations. "Teamwork is the only way to succeed," he would often remind them.

As Rob walked through one of Ascend's busy hallways, he noticed Ricardo, one of the logistics workers, struggling with a stack of boxes. Turning a corner, a few boxes slipped from Ricardo's grasp and scattered across the floor. Without hesitation, Rob bent down to help him pick them up.

"Whoa, let me give you a hand!" Rob said, picking up one of the boxes.

"Oh, no, sir—please," Ricardo stammered. "This is my job."

"Ricardo," Rob replied with a grin, "we're all in this together. How's everything going?"

Ricardo smiled sheepishly. "Good, good. We just wanted to say thanks for the new stock options program."

Rob's face lit up. "Success is better when it's shared, right guys?" he said, turning to the other employees nearby. They all nodded in agreement.

One of the other workers, John, glanced at a photo in his hand. "Just got a letter from my daughter in Chicago with pictures of my grandkids."

Rob peered at the photo, a warm smile spreading across his face. "You know what's great? Soon, she won't even need to buy stamps. She'll just press a button, and this beautiful picture will go straight into your email—at lightning speed."

John chuckled. "Will your device let me hug my grandkids without getting on a plane, too?"

Rob scratched his chin thoughtfully. "I'll see what I can do," he replied with a wink, prompting laughter from the group.

As Rob walked down the hallway, Yosif Kumar, dressed in an expensive suit, approached with an eager expression on his face.

"Mr. Ryan?" Yosif called out.

"That's me," Rob said, turning to face him.

"I'm Yosif Kumar. I applied for the Director of Production position."

"Oh, you're Charles' recommendation," Rob said, glancing at him appraisingly.

They continued walking down the hall together, Rob exuding his usual casual confidence. Yosif struggled to keep up as Rob stopped abruptly in front of a stack of boxes.

"You know what this is?" Rob asked, tapping the box.

Yosif blinked. "Ascend's new product for the ISP market?"

"Correct," Rob said with a grin. "We call it the 'pizza box'. But we've been getting complaints that the product's arriving damaged."

Without warning, Rob slammed the box onto the floor. Yosif jumped back, startled, as Rob stomped on it for good measure. He then picked it up and gave it a shake, the rattling sound unmistakable.

"I'm going to need you to figure out how to protect this thing from people like me!" Rob said, chuckling.

Yosif laughed nervously. “Does this mean I’m hired?”

Rob winked. “If Charles says you’re the man for the job, who am I to argue? After all, Charles and I see eye to eye on... just about everything.”

As they continued walking, Rob glanced around the office. “We need to expand production. The product’s selling like hotcakes, but we’re using teaspoons when we need bulldozers.”

Yosif furrowed his brow. “What’s stopping us?”

Rob stopped abruptly, causing Yosif to nearly bump into him. “Financing,” Rob said with a sigh. “We’re sitting on a gold mine, and we need to go public.”

“What’s stopping you?” Yosif asked again.

“The board—they don’t trust me.”

“Why not?” Yosif pressed.

Rob shrugged. “Maybe it’s because I don’t wear a suit. Maybe it’s because I say exactly what I think. Who knows?”

Yosif smiled. “Well, going public will let us acquire other companies, create greater synergy.”

Rob shook his head. “No. We need to go public so we can continue to innovate.”

Yosif nodded. “I’ll help you any way I can.”

Rob clapped Yosif on the back. “Not me, Yosif— "us". Help "us".”

Rob stopped in the middle of the workspace and spread his arms wide. "This is going to be huge!"

Chapter 16: Going public

Rob stood at the head of the table, scanning the room. The board members sat in silence, their expressions a mix of curiosity and suspicion. He took a deep breath. "I think it's time we take the next big step forward."

David Kingston leaned forward, frowning. "And what exactly is this 'next step' you're talking about?"

Rob smiled, excitement flashing in his eyes. "Going public. It's time for Ascend to launch an IPO."

The room fell into a heavy silence, tension thickening the air. David raised an eyebrow, his voice skeptical. "You really think we're ready for that? This company's still young, Rob. The public market is ruthless, and we're not exactly seasoned."

Charles York, arms crossed, finally spoke, his tone sharp. "David's right. We've done well so far, but video conferencing and this internet stuff… it's not guaranteed to last. You know how these tech trends go."

Rob stepped forward, his energy palpable. "Tech trends? This isn't a trend, Charles. The internet is about to explode, and we're sitting right at the center of it. Every ISP out there is begging for our solution. Our routing technology doesn't just handle video—it handles data. And data is everything: news, games, commerce, communication. Ascend isn't just solving problems; we're shaping the future."

David adjusted his glasses, still doubtful. "The market is volatile, Rob. There's risk."

"Of course there's risk," Rob shot back, "but what's innovation without risk? We've been profitable for four straight quarters. We've proven our model works. Now we have the chance to dominate the global market. We can be the backbone of the internet—not just here, but everywhere. Think of the possibilities: streaming video, online shopping, real-time communication. Ascend can own this space. We can be kings."

Charles leaned forward; his voice cool. "What about competition? Cisco won't just sit back. We could be crushed before we even reach the public market. And frankly, I'm not sure the management team is ready for this kind of pressure."

Rob's eyes flashed with determination. "Cisco? We've already beaten them to the punch in video conferencing, and we'll do it again with data routing. They're playing catch-up while we're leading. As for the management team, we've adapted at every turn. This company started in Trey's home kitchen, and now we're a global leader in digital communication. If we've come this far, we can take it all the way."

The room buzzed with nervous energy. Tim, who had been silently observing, cleared his throat. "You're talking about a global vision, Rob. You really believe Ascend can compete on that scale?"

Rob's face lit up. "Tim, we're not just competing—we're going to win. The internet is in its infancy, and the number of applications we can power is limitless. From telemedicine to online banking, from education to entertainment. Ascend is going to be at the heart of it all. We're building the infrastructure for the world of tomorrow, and we'll own it."

Tim’s eyebrows rose. "You’re talking about being the ‘King of the Internet’?"

"Exactly," Rob said with a confident grin. "We’re not just going to compete—we’re going to lead. We’ll measure our success by how we dominate every layer of the market. Any-to-any communication, international interfaces, customer-premise products—you name it, we’ll control it. That’s what I mean by King of."

Charles smirked. "And what if your crown doesn’t fit? What if this is all just ambition without a real plan?"

Rob didn’t miss a beat. "The plan is in motion, Charles. We’ve already solved some of the internet’s biggest problems. It’s not about if we’ll lead—it’s about when. And the answer is now."

Charles leaned back in his chair, a smug look on his face. "Well, let’s see if the rest of the board is as convinced as you are." He glanced around. "I think it’s time to put this to a vote."

The room stilled. Slowly, one of the board members raised his hand. Then another. And another. The tension mounted as one by one, the board members signaled their approval.

Finally, all eyes turned to Charles. He sat there, clearly displeased, his hand hovering in the air. After a long, deliberate pause, he sighed, raising his hand.

A cynical smile curled on his lips. "Looks like we’re all in agreement, Rob. Onward to the IPO."

Rob’s face broke into a grin, but Charles’ words hung in the air like a veiled threat. The victory was his, but the battle with Charles was far from over.

תודה על ההבהרות. הנה גרסה חדשה שמדגישה את התכונות החשובות של רוב, תוך שמירה על התוכן והמסר החינוכי ליזמים ומקצרת מעט באורך.

Rob stood at the head of the conference room, the board members murmuring after approving the IPO. He’d won the battle, but now reality hit—he’d never done an IPO before and had no idea where to start.

“So... I guess our next steps are to set this in motion. What do we need? Who do we bring in?” Rob asked, scanning the room.

Tim Kinsley leaned forward. “We’ll need bankers—maybe someone from Piper in the Midwest, and Hambrecht & Quist out in California. And we should also get someone from a big firm, like Morgan Stanley.”

Rob nodded, appreciating the mix of small boutique firms and big names. "Alright, let's get started."

As the IPO process unfolded, the workload increased dramatically. Rob was juggling meetings with financial pros, accountants, and legal teams, all while preparing Ascend for the big leap. They hired Bob Dahl as CFO to handle the complex financial regulations, though Rob was amused by Bob’s stiff demeanor.

On Bob's first day, he approached Rob. "I need you to assemble my staff."

Rob grinned. "Assemble? Like LEGO bricks? You've got three people, Bob. We don't do 'staff' here."

Bob blinked. "Three people? For a company going public?"

"That's right," Rob replied, watching Bob storm off, clearly rattled by Ascend's lean operation. But Rob was confident—it was enough to get them through the IPO.

As Ascend continued to grow, the team worked on the IPO pitch. Jacob, their speech coach, was tasked with turning Rob, Mike Bon, and Bob into an efficient presentation team. Jacob's critique was direct but fair.

"Mike, you're doing great. Keep up the good work," Jacob said. "But Rob," he turned to him, "you need to connect more with the audience. You've got an amazing story, but you're not telling it in a way that makes people feel it."

Rob nodded. "So what do I need to do?"

"Picture yourself in a cozy Irish pub," Jacob said, leaning forward. "You're telling a story to friends, not making a formal presentation. Make it personal, get them invested. Make them feel like they're part of it."

Rob smiled, imagining himself in that pub, telling stories like he had done with old friends. He knew Jacob was right. This wasn't just about numbers—it was about selling the vision, the passion.

The roadshow began, with Rob and the team presenting to potential investors across the country. Rob quickly discovered that not every meeting would be easy.

In one session, a stocky investor raised his hand. "You're holding back on us. I know there's more revenue you're not showing. What's in the reserves?"

Rob's eyes narrowed. The man was right. There were millions in reserves that they hadn't reported, money set aside for possible returns. But Rob believed in transparency. "Look," he said, "there's revenue we could report, but we're being conservative. We don't count the money until it's 100% guaranteed."

The investor pressed, "How much are we talking?"

Rob grinned. "I'd love to tell you, but then I'd have to kill you."

The room erupted in laughter, but the investor didn't let up. "We can't invest without knowing that number."

Rob's patience thinned. "Listen, you come up here and run the company, and I'll sit in your chair and fiddle with spreadsheets. I'm growing this business at a massive rate, and you're telling me that's not good enough?"

The investor backed down, raising his hands. "Alright, you've made your point. I'm still in."

Rob knew then—honesty was a powerful tool. Investors respected straight talk, even if it wasn't what they wanted to hear.

In another meeting, the inevitable question came up: "How are you going to compete with Cisco? They're the biggest player in the networking space."

Rob took a breath, pulling out a poster board. "Good question. There are four key areas that matter in this market: routing, wide area networking, network management, and protocols."

He began marking the board, giving Cisco credit where it was due. "Cisco leads in routing, no doubt about it. But when it comes to wide area networking, that's where Ascend shines. We're both strong in the other two areas."

The investors looked confused. Rob had essentially presented a tie, which wasn't exactly reassuring.

He let the tension hang for a moment. Then, with a flourish, he circled one word on the board: **Protocols**.

"But here's the thing," Rob continued. "Cisco may have more protocols, but we only need one. One protocol that will dominate the future of the internet—and we're the only ones who have it."

The room buzzed with excitement. They were starting to understand the potential. Rob handed the presentation off to Mike, who explained the technical aspects in detail. By the end, the investors were on board.

The roadshow continued, with Rob, Mike, and Bob hitting city after city, refining their pitch and winning over investors. But Rob was feeling the strain. His back ached constantly, and the constant travel was wearing him down.

A few weeks later, after the final round of presentations, Ascend's IPO launched—and it was a resounding success. The stock soared on the first day, and the team celebrated the victory. Rob, despite the exhaustion, couldn't help but feel a sense of pride. Ascend was on the map, and they'd done it their way—by being honest, innovative, and relentless.

As the champagne flowed and the team celebrated, Rob sat back, reflecting on the journey. They had come so far, and there was still so much more to do. But for tonight, they had earned this victory.

Chapter 17: A storm in the horizons

Rob sat on the edge of the hotel bed in London, Terry joined him in this trip, hoping to help ease the burden. Carrying their luggage supporting Rob in every aspect. They were a power couple. The phone pressed to his ear. The sounds of the city outside were distant, but his focus was entirely on the conversation with Yosif.

"Hey, Rob," Yosif began. "How did it go with the new customers?"

Rob glanced at Terry, who was stepping out of the bathroom in her robe. He rubbed his temple, trying to push away the creeping fatigue. "It went really well," he replied. But before Yosif could respond, Rob pressed on, "But what's this I'm hearing about the board? They want us to start buying companies. Was that your idea?"

Yosif hesitated. "Yeah... It's a quicker way to grow. The thinking is to stop wasting time and money on new development and just buy companies that already have the solutions we need. I thought it would help, and I shared the idea with the board... After all, you want the company to grow quickly too, right? I'm trying to help you."

Rob's expression tightened. "Helping me? By going behind my back?" His voice sharpened. "Acquiring other companies is a huge mistake. Buying someone else's technology means we lose what makes us unique. Our strength is in staying ahead, not catching up with someone else's product."

"But the board is worried," Yosif said cautiously. "They're focused on the returns, Rob. They want profits now, not later. I'm just trying to keep them happy."

Rob stood, pacing around the hotel room. "I'm not against profits, Yosif. I want the company to make big money. But real success doesn't come from short-term thinking. If we focus on developing our own tech, we'll stay the 'king of' our space. It's not about being the biggest today—it's about being the company that defines tomorrow."

Terry, overhearing the conversation, approached Rob with concern on her face. "What's wrong?" she whispered, but Rob gestured for her to hold off.

"Listen, Yosif," Rob continued, "if you think throwing money at the problem will solve it, you're missing the point. Our edge is our innovation. If we start buying other people's solutions, we're giving up our lead. We'll end up like the rest—always chasing, never leading."

There was a pause on the other end. "But the investors... they're nervous. They want to see returns now."

"They'll get their money," Rob said, his voice firm. "And not just a little. If we stay the course, they'll make ten times what they're expecting. You just have to trust me on this."

"But the board," Yosif pressed, "they're not in it for the innovation. They want to see returns."

"Leave the investors to me," Rob said, his irritation barely contained. "You just make sure everything runs smoothly. I'll handle the rest."

"You can count on me, Rob," Yosif replied, his tone softer now.

Rob hung up, sighing as Terry came closer in her blue bathrobe, concern deepening on her face.

“Damn it,” Rob muttered, frustration spilling over. “Talking to him is like talking to Charles. They don’t get the bigger picture.”

Terry placed a hand on his arm, trying to calm him. “I don’t trust him either. Yosif asked me the other day why he hasn’t gotten a gold watch yet. I told him that’s only for CEOs, and he gave me this strange look... mumbling something about how ‘sometimes things happen faster than they seem.’”

Rob raised an eyebrow. “A gold watch? That’s what’s on his mind?” He shook his head. “I don’t know... He and Charles have been acting strange lately. Always questioning my strategy.”

His tone softened as he looked into Terry’s eyes. “I’m not here to play games. I know what’s best for this company. We need to be the ‘king of’ every field we enter. If we lose that edge, we lose everything.”

Terry sighed, giving him a small smile. "Okay, fine. But can we just forget about work for one day? We’re in London, remember? This is supposed to be better than our honeymoon."

Rob chuckled, pulling her close. "What was wrong with our honeymoon?"

Terry raised an eyebrow. "Well, for one, you never carried me across the threshold."

Rob pretended to be shocked. "I didn’t?"

She shook her head, playfully disappointed. "Nope."

Rob laughed, standing up and sweeping her into his arms. "Well, let me fix that right now."

But as he lifted her, a sharp pain shot through his back, causing him to wince and stumble. "Arrghh—oh, God!" he groaned, collapsing onto the bed.

Terry rushed to his side, her concern turning real. "Rob, are you okay?"

Yosif sat at his desk, eyes fixed on the documents in front of him, when the door creaked open, and two of Ascend’s engineers, Mark and Evan, walked in. Their faces were tense, reflecting the urgency of the situation.

"Yosif, we need to talk," Mark began, glancing at Evan for support. "We’ve been waiting for the budget approval to move forward with the development Rob signed off on."

Yosif didn’t look up immediately, letting the silence linger before finally leaning back in his chair, his fingers lightly tapping the desk. "I’m aware of the proposal," he said, voice measured. "But for now, the development budget is frozen."

Mark frowned. "Frozen? Rob was clear about this. We’re supposed to start this week—he’s expecting results soon."

Yosif met their gaze, his tone taking on a colder edge. "Rob is in recovery, you know that he had this spine surgery…... He's not in the best position to make decisions right now."

The room felt suddenly heavier. Evan stepped forward, trying to push back. "But this was part of Rob's strategy—to keep us ahead, to ensure we don't fall behind. We need to act quickly. He's counting on us."

Yosif's lips curled into a subtle smirk. "Let's be honest here, Rob's been a bit… impulsive lately. The man's been through a lot. I think we can all agree his focus might not be entirely clear at the moment."

Mark's confusion deepened. "Rob trusts us to deliver. We can't just stop now. He's going to expect updates when he gets back."

Yosif's eyes narrowed, his voice growing firmer. "Rob won't be back in full capacity for a while, and until then, I'm the one handling priorities. Right now, we're putting the budget on hold, and that's not up for debate."

The engineers exchanged uneasy glances, sensing a shift they hadn't anticipated. There was no room left for argument. Mark finally nodded, resignation in his eyes. "Understood. We'll let the team know."

They turned to leave, the air heavy with confusion and uncertainty. As they walked out, Evan whispered under his breath, "Who's running this company now?"

A few weeks after his spine surgery, Rob lay in bed, groaning softly as he held the phone to his ear, calling Yosif at his office. "How are you, Rob?" Yosif's voice came through the line, his tone carrying a trace of frustration, as if Rob's call had interrupted something more pressing.
"The disc slipped half an inch—pressed against the spinal cord." Rob said, shifting uncomfortably.

"What caused it?"

"Too many nights in bad hotel beds while doing IPO presentations in every damn city," Rob muttered. "Doc says I'll need six weeks of bed rest."

"Six months," Terry whispered from beside him, her lips pressed into a thin line.

Rob silenced her with a finger to his lips, then turned back to the phone. "Six weeks," he repeated.

"Take as much time as you need," Yosif said reassuringly. "I'm here for you."

Rob wasn't convinced. "Yeah, well, just stick to the plan, okay? Don't deviate from the strategy. I'll be in touch every day. Everything should proceed as usual."

Yosif's voice was steady, but something about it didn't sit right with Rob. "Of course. I'll do what's best for the company, Rob. You can trust me."

"Okay," Rob said, ending the call. But as he looked over at Terry, he frowned. "I don't know... He was a little too nice."

Yosif hung up the phone, turning to face Charles York, who was lounging on the couch with a smug smile, sipping a drink.

Charles raised his glass slightly, his eyes glinting with mischief. "Spinal surgery, huh? Couldn't have come at a better time."

Yosif didn't reply, but the implication was clear. Charles stood up, motioning for Yosif to follow him. "Come on. Let's talk."

Yosif followed Charles down the hallway, passing by Stacy, who watched them curiously from a distance. She noticed Charles leading Yosif toward Rob's office and felt a strange knot form in her stomach.

Inside the office, Charles gestured toward Rob's chair. "Have a seat," he said, pointing to the chair behind the desk.

Yosif hesitated. "You mean... Rob's chair?"

Charles nodded, a slight smile playing at the corners of his mouth. "It's time for a dynamic leader to step in. Go ahead."

Stacy sighed, sinking into the chair, her head in her hands. Something was happening, and she knew it. Her relationship with Rob had been strained lately, and with Terry... well, things hadn't been the same since the incident. Still, she didn't trust Yosif, and the unease gnawed at her. She hesitated, conflicted, before finally picking up the phone and dialing quickly.

The line rang twice before Terry's voice came through.

"Ryan residence, Terry speaking."

Stacy had been hoping Rob would answer. She wasn't in the mood to talk to Terry. Her fingers gripped the receiver tightly as she hesitated, unsure of what to say. Terry's voice came again, more insistent. "Hello? Anyone there?"

Stacy's stomach churned. After a few more seconds, she abruptly hung up the phone. Glancing back toward Rob's office, she saw Yosif chatting with Charles and Tim through the glass partition. Her gut twisted as she caught the faint sound of Yosif's voice, and a sense of unease settled over her.

"This surgery couldn't have come at a better time... Let's start changing priorities."

Charles chuckled. "Finally. It's about time this company had a dynamic leader."

Chapter 18: The Final Betrayal

Rob and Terry pulled into the parking lot of Ascend's headquarters, the company they had built together. The license plate on their car read *ASCEND 1*, a subtle reminder of Rob's dedication and leadership. As Rob brought the car to a stop, he smiled at Terry.

"How do you feel?" she asked, her voice calm but concerned.

"Ready," Rob replied confidently, glancing toward the office building.

Terry placed a hand on his arm. "Just remember, you're still healing. Please, take it slow today."

Rob chuckled. "Slow? What are you talking about? I'm Rob Mount 2.0 now. I've been upgraded. My head is spinning with new ideas. The board is going to lose their minds when I show them what's next."

Terry, knowing his enthusiasm, smiled faintly. "Honey, I love you, but... please, just don't push yourself."

Rob grinned. "Fine. Slow, right?"

Terry nodded. "Mmm-hmm."

"One hundred miles per hour it is," Rob teased as he opened the door and stepped out, grabbing his briefcase with a fresh burst of energy.

"Real slow, Rob. Real slow," Terry called after him, laughing softly.

They exchanged a kiss, a quiet moment in the bustling parking lot. Rob could already see some of the shareholders approaching, smiling and ready to welcome him back. As he made his way toward the entrance, Ricardo, one of the longtime employees, hurried over.

"Mr. Ryan!" Ricardo called, beaming.

"Hey, Ricardo! Good to see you!" Rob replied, shaking his hand warmly.

"I just wanted to say thank you in person," Ricardo said, his voice full of gratitude. "My daughter was accepted to Stanford, and I could never have afforded it without the stock options. You changed our lives."

Rob smiled, his heart swelling with pride. "That's wonderful, Ricardo. I'm glad I could help."

As Rob and Ricardo finished their conversation, more shareholders began to gather around. Applause erupted, catching Rob slightly off guard. The energy was infectious, the kind of reception that made everything he'd been through over the past nine months' worth it.

"Thank you, thank you all!" Rob waved to the crowd, overwhelmed by the support. He could feel the weight of their admiration, their trust in his leadership.

He stepped inside the building, heading toward the conference room where the shareholders' meeting was about to begin. As he entered, the room buzzed with excitement. Shareholders from

all corners of the country had come to hear from the man who had brought Ascend to its current heights.

Inside, Rob was met with smiles, nods of approval, and even a few pats on the back. He stood at the front, adjusting his posture before speaking.

“Thank you all for the warm welcome,” Rob began, his voice steady but full of emotion. “It’s great to be back. These past months have been tough, but I’m ready to jump back in and take Ascend even further.”

The shareholders erupted into applause, the energy lifting Rob even higher. For a moment, everything seemed perfect. Rob’s vision for the company, his drive to innovate, and the belief the shareholders had in him—it all aligned seamlessly.

“I promise you,” Rob continued, “we’ve only just scratched the surface of what Ascend can achieve. I’m here, fully back, and ready to lead us to even greater success.”

After more applause and rounds of handshakes, the meeting wrapped up on a high note. Rob basked in the goodwill of the shareholders as they filtered out, their trust in him stronger than ever.

But as the room emptied, Rob noticed the shift. The shareholders had left, but the board members remained. Charles, Yosif, and the others stayed behind, their expressions far more measured, the warmth from earlier quickly fading. They all moved to a smaller room to start the board meeting. The positive energy was being replaced by something far more formal—and far more ominous. The real meeting was about to begin. ---

Rob poured himself a drink from a beverage can, trying to keep the energy light.

“I mean, there were so many shareholders out there, cheering. I wasn’t expecting any of that. It was... overwhelming,” Rob chuckled, raising his glass slightly.

But the room remained quiet, the board members exchanging uneasy glances. Charles York, seated across the table, cleared his throat.

“That’s great to hear, Rob,” Charles began, his tone cool and measured. “We’re thrilled you’re back. But we... we do have some concerns.”

Rob laughed, not quite understanding. “Concerns? What could possibly be wrong, Charles? The company’s not making enough money for you?”

The joke fell flat. The faces around the table remained stoic, unmoved by Rob’s humor. The atmosphere shifted, becoming tense.

“Actually, the projections aren’t as rosy as we’d like them to be,” one of the board members, an older man, spoke up. “R&D is eating up too much of our budget.”

Rob felt a sudden flare of irritation. “The internet has the potential to reshape the world, it’s practically as dangerous and transformative as an atomic bomb. We have a responsibility to the users, to keep pushing boundaries—and that requires R&D.”

Charles leaned forward, his expression hard. “Safety is not our mandate, Rob. Profit is. We need to widen the freeway and secure more of it.”

“Come on, guys,” Rob said, his frustration showing. “You all saw the shareholders out there. They’re thrilled with the direction of the company. They gave me a standing ovation, for God’s sake!”

Silence. The board members exchanged uneasy glances once more.

Another member, this time Yosif, squirmed slightly in his seat. “Rob, with all due respect, you’ve been away from the company for a while.”

“I’ve been here every day remotely,” Rob snapped. “I may have been recovering, but I was still present.”

Charles glanced toward Yosif and then back to Rob. “Things have changed while you’ve been gone. Quite frankly, the board no longer believes you're the right person to lead Ascend into the future.”

Rob’s heart skipped a beat. “What are you talking about? You just approved my three-year plan.”

“Yes, but we’re thinking about the long-term future,” Charles said, his voice oozing condescension. “We need someone more... flexible. Someone with a bit more acumen to take Ascend to the next level.”

Rob stared at the faces around the table, suddenly aware that something much bigger had been brewing in his absence. “What’s going on here?”

One of the board members nodded toward Yosif. “Maybe Yosif can shed some light on this, given he’s been filling your role.”

Rob turned to Yosif, his eyes narrowing. “You?”

Yosif shifted uncomfortably before speaking. “Rob, you did an incredible job... considering the circumstances. But things have evolved, and the board thinks it’s time for a change.”

Rob couldn’t believe what he was hearing. “You asshole,” he muttered under his breath.

Tim, who had been silent until now, leaned forward, trying to smooth things over. “There’s no need for hostility, Rob. We all agree, Ascend has great potential to expand—”

“Yeah, because of me!” Rob shouted, slamming his hand on the table.

“No one’s denying that,” Tim said gently. “But the world is changing. We need someone who can explore new ways to increase profitability. There are competitors coming up, and we need to stay ahead.”

Charles jumped in, his tone clipped. “There are alternatives that are more cost-effective and involve less risk. Mergers, acquisitions—”

“Shut up!” Rob barked at Yosif, his patience snapping. “I don’t want to hear another word out of you.”

A cold silence fell over the room. Rob could feel the walls closing in around him.

Another board member spoke up. “Rob, we’d be happy for you to stay on as Chairman of the Board—”

“Fuck all of you!” Rob spat, glaring at Charles. “You planned this, didn’t you? All of it.”

Charles raised an eyebrow, unfazed. “All those in favor of nominating Yosif as our new CEO, raise your hand.”

One by one, the hands went up around the table. Rob watched in horror as Tim’s hand slowly joined the others. Finally, Charles raised his own.

“It’s unanimous,” Charles said, his voice dripping with satisfaction.

Rob sat back in his chair, the weight of the betrayal crushing him. “Jesus. One minute it’s all smiles and tributes, the next it’s a dagger to the heart.”

As his eyes scanned the room, he spotted Stacy standing outside the glass partition, watching the scene unfold. She lowered her gaze, avoiding his eyes, and in that moment, Rob knew she had been part of this, too.

“You too, Stacy?” he muttered under his breath.

Charles stood up, signaling the end of the meeting. “This meeting is adjourned. Congratulations, Yosif.”

As the board members filed out, Tim lingered behind, looking at Rob with a mixture of sympathy and regret.

“It’s just business, Rob,” Tim said softly. “We’re doing what’s best for the company.”

Rob’s face twisted with anger. “Companies are made of people. And they should live by the same moral standards we do in life. You promised to watch my back, to protect me from Trojan horses. This isn’t business, Tim. This is two-faced bullshit. Get out of here.”

Tim hesitated but then raised his hands in surrender and walked out.

Outside the conference room, a small celebration was taking place. As Terry arrived, she paused, looking through the window into the meeting room where Rob sat alone, his face pale and his hands resting on the table, motionless. Just outside in the lobby, she saw Charles fastening a large gold watch onto Yosif’s wrist. The watch gleamed, a clear symbol of power and status—the kind only CEOs of major companies wore. Terry understood immediately.

Without hesitation, she entered the room where Rob sat, his head bowed, lost in thought. She moved quietly to his side, knelt down, and took his hand. Rob looked up at her, his eyes filled

with a mix of sorrow and anger. She embraced him without a word, holding him tightly as his emotions swirled, both knowing that everything had just changed.

Rick and Mike stood nearby, watching the scene unfold. They exchanged guilty glances, knowing they had been complicit in this downfall.

Chapter 19: After Ascend

Rob stood at the wooden fence of their summer house in Yosemite, a hammer in hand and nails clamped between his teeth. The bright afternoon sun cast long shadows across the yard, but Rob's focus was on the fence. He checked its stability, tested it with a light tap, and, finding it wobbly, started hammering. The sound of the hammer echoed in the calm, but it didn't quiet the storm inside him.

Terry watched him from the front porch, her arms folded. She could feel the tension in his movements—every swing of the hammer, every breath he took. From where she stood, it looked like he was trying to fix more than just a fence.

Her thoughts wandered back to everything that had happened. Rob had been forced out of Ascend, the company he'd built from the ground up. Yet they had walked away with more money than they had ever dreamed. The severance package had been incredibly generous, mostly because the board didn't want any negative publicity. But Rob didn't care about the money. It was never about the money for him. Ascend had been his life's work, a symbol of all the failures he had overcome, the victories he had won. And now, it had been taken from him.

Terry watched him struggle with the fence. One of the boards came loose, and she saw the frustration in his face as he pounded it back into place, harder than necessary. Then, something snapped inside him. His jaw clenched, and he started banging on the fence wildly, splintering the wood with furious blows. The hammer hit the ground with a thud as he let out a low, guttural groan, walking away from the broken fence.

A few days later, Terry found herself hurrying through the lobby of a hotel for a business meeting. As she made her way up the stairs, she spotted Stacy, the woman who had once been Rob's ally, standing by a table with two children and another woman. Terry paused. She hadn't seen Stacy in a while, and the sight of her now brought up too many emotions.

"Stacy," Terry called out.

Stacy looked up, surprised. "Terry... hi. How are you?"

Terry's lips curled into a bitter smile. "How am I? How are you?"

Stacy seemed taken aback by the sharpness in Terry's voice. "I'm doing well, thanks. These are my kids, Rebecca and Toby," she said, pointing to the table. "And that's Jo-Ann, my partner."

Terry blinked, surprised. "You have kids?" she asked, her voice flat.

"Yeah, and that's Jo-Ann," Stacy repeated, looking a little uncomfortable now.

Terry crossed her arms. "Well, isn't that ironic," she said coldly. "I hope you treat her better than you treated your last partner."

Stacy's smile vanished. "Excuse me?"

“At least you could have called. You know, to check how he was doing?” Terry’s voice trembled with anger. “After everything?”

Stacy shifted uncomfortably. “I figured he had you to take care of him, so what was the point?”

Terry shook her head, her eyes narrowing. “And yet, while we were working together, you couldn’t even show a little decency.”

Stacy sighed, exasperated. “It was nothing personal, Terry. It was just business.”

Terry let out a bitter laugh. “Yeah, well, that seems to be everyone’s excuse these days, doesn’t it?” She turned abruptly, leaving Stacy standing there as she walked toward her meeting, her heart heavy with unresolved anger.

Back at home, Rob was sitting on the couch, staring down at a Sudoku puzzle, ignoring the blaring television in the background. The broadcast was discussing the rising dangers of cyberbullying, but Rob barely registered the words. He was lost in the numbers, seeking some form of logic in the grid in front of him. Numbers made sense—people did not.

Terry walked into the room, watching him with growing concern. “Rob?” she called softly.

“Yeah?” he replied, not looking up.

“Do you want something to eat?” she asked, her voice edged with frustration.

“Later,” he muttered.

“You said that three hours ago,” Terry replied sharply. “It’s later now.”

“Later,” Rob repeated, his focus still on the puzzle.

Terry let out an exasperated sigh. “When do you think you might be done?”

“I don’t know. When it’s done,” he shot back. “At least numbers have logic. People… not so much.”

Terry crossed her arms, her patience wearing thin. “How long is this going to go on, Rob?”

“As long as I want it to,” he muttered.

“It’s depressing,” Terry said, her voice breaking with frustration.

“You wouldn’t understand,” Rob snapped, finally looking up.

“Oh, I wouldn’t?” Terry replied, her voice rising. “Because I’m not an engineer? I’m not a mathematician, or a scientist? Well, let me remind you, Rob—I’m your partner. I’ve always been your biggest fan. And if you can’t appreciate that, I don’t know what else to tell you.”

She stormed out of the room, the sound of pots and pans crashing in the kitchen. Rob stared after her, his irritation growing. "What's the big deal?" he muttered to himself.

The phone rang, but Rob ignored it. When it rang again, Terry's voice came from the kitchen. "For god's sake, Rob, turn down the TV and answer the phone!"

Rob turned down the volume and reluctantly answered the phone. "Yeah?"

"Mr. Ryan?" The voice on the other end was formal.

"Who's asking?" Rob replied, his tone impatient.

"This is William Bennett from the Silicon Valley Entrepreneur of the Year committee. I'm calling to inform you that you're one of the four finalists in the Communications Technology Sector."

Rob blinked, taken aback. "Is this some kind of joke?"

"Far from it," Bennett replied. "This is one of the most prestigious awards in the field."

Rob's eyes darkened. "Yeah, well, I don't trust anyone in this field anymore. All they do is stab you in the back."

Terry walked back into the room, watching Rob's expression shift. "Who is it?" she asked.

Rob ignored her, holding up a hand to signal her to wait. "Speak to my wife," he said flatly, handing Terry the phone and walking out the door without another word.

Terry took the phone, watching him go, her heart heavy with concern.

A few weeks later, Rob and Terry sat at a large, round table at the Silicon Valley Entrepreneur of the Year awards ceremony. A single sunflower stood in a vase at the center of the table, a quiet symbol of everything they had endured together. The table bore a sign that read "Ascend Communications Guests," but all the chairs around them were conspicuously empty.

"Did you prepare a speech?" Terry asked softly.

Rob glanced around at the vacant seats. "They're not going to give it to me," he muttered. "They'll probably pick some boring guy in a nice gray suit. And as you can see, Yosif made sure none of the team bothered to show up."

Terry scribbled something on a napkin and handed it to Rob. "Just in case," she said.

Rob rolled his eyes and refused to take it, "There is no point." He said.

The ceremony continued, and soon enough, the moment arrived.

“Ladies and gentlemen,” the moderator announced, “the winner of the Silicon Valley Entrepreneur of the Year in Communications Technology is... Rob Ryan!”

The room exploded in applause as Rob rose to his feet, still in disbelief. He turned to Terry, who smiled warmly, holding out the napkin once more. “Go on,” she whispered, her voice steady with encouragement. Rob took the napkin, stuffing it into his pocket as he made his way to the stage. The cheers continued as he stepped up to the podium, accepting the award from the moderator with a gracious nod.

“Thank you,” he began, feeling the weight of the moment. He paused, his hands trembling slightly as he unfolded the napkin. Written in Terry’s familiar handwriting were the words: “Don’t forget to thank your customers. Some of them are here.”

Rob smiled, glancing at Terry briefly before turning to the crowd.
“First, I want to thank our customers,” he began. “Without your trust and belief in us, none of this would’ve been possible. Whether you’re a giant tech company in Silicon Valley or a small operation running out of a basement, it’s your faith that has brought us here today.”

The crowd clapped politely, but Rob wasn’t finished. With a sly smile, he turned his attention to the sunflower vase on the table next to him. “But now,” he said with a playful twinkle in his eye, “I’d like to thank two more important contributors.”

He stepped toward the table, reached for a sunflower, and held it up for the crowd to see. “First, this,” he said, raising the flower. The audience looked at him, puzzled. “A sunflower. Yes, I’d like to thank this little flower, which symbolizes more than you might think. You’re probably wondering, ‘What’s so special about a sunflower? What does it have to do with success?’ Well,” Rob paused, letting the suspense build, “you’ll have to wait for my upcoming book to find out.”

Laughter rippled through the crowd as people clapped, enjoying Rob’s unexpected twist. He waited for the noise to subside, then his tone shifted, becoming more heartfelt.

“And now, for the most important thank you of all,” Rob said, his eyes locking with Terry’s in the audience. “My wife, Terry. She’s not just my partner in life, but my partner in everything. She’s been there through all the ups and downs, supporting me, dealing with every crazy idea I’ve ever had, and never once complaining. She is the reason I stand here today. She’s the queen behind this whole operation.”

The crowd exploded into applause, louder than before. As Rob stepped off the stage, he made his way toward Terry, holding the award in one hand and the sunflower in the other. When he reached her, he handed her both – the award and the flower – and kissed her on the cheek. The audience’s cheers grew even louder, recognizing not just the success of Rob, but the triumph of a partnership that had weathered every storm together.

This was their moment of victory, shared as equals.

Chapter 20: Rising Again

"Rob, why are you just sitting here?" Terry's voice broke through the silence, firm but caring. She stood in the doorway, arms crossed, her eyes locked on Rob, who was lounging on the couch, staring blankly at the TV. "Why don't you do something with yourself? Forget the past and start enjoying the present."

Rob sighed, not even looking away from the screen. "Enjoy the present? Like what, Terry? Ascend is gone. Everything I built… gone. What am I supposed to do now?"

Terry raised an eyebrow. "Well, isn't it ironic that the guy who taught others how to find their strengths never sat down to do a Sunflower process for himself?"

Rob blinked, surprised. "You think I need to do that? For me?"

"Absolutely," Terry said, sitting down beside him. "Have you ever truly analyzed your own strengths? Your core identity? What are your seeds, Rob? What are your real assets, your passion, your knowledge, your unique skills? You've always said that once someone understands who they are, they can see what new 'petals' they can grow. So why not do the same for yourself?"

It was a 'Eureka' moment for Rob. She was right. He had always been the one guiding other through the process, teaching them to break down their ideas, their assets, and their potential. But now, as Terry pointed out, he needed to turn that process inward. He needed to see himself as he saw other businesses: full of potential.

Rob sat up straighter, his mind already buzzing. "You know what, Terry? You're right. Let's see… my strengths: creativity, leadership, experience in scaling businesses, strategic thinking… and as results I can grow a new petal as a mentor. I can guide others to find their way."

Terry smiled. "Exactly. You can teach them how to ask the right questions. Showing them how to find the solutions themselves.

And as always in Rob's life, reality quickly followed inspiration. No sooner had he made the decision to move forward than the phone rang.

A young entrepreneur named Andrew Feinberg was on the line. "Rob, I heard about your success with Ascend. I've got a company, but it's just not taking off like I hoped. I was wondering if you could help me figure out what I'm missing."

Rob smiled. This was it—the chance to test out his theory. "Sure thing, Andrew," Rob replied. "But remember, I'm not going to give you the answers. What I'm going to do is help you ask the right questions." At first, Andrew struggled to answer. But as the session went on, Rob's questions forced him to think deeply about his business, his goals, and his resources. Slowly but surely, Andrew began to see where the real opportunities lay. He realized that the technology his company had developed was being underutilized. In fact, it could solve a massive problem for telephone companies by helping them track and visualize their equipment networks—something that no one else in the market was offering at the time.

By the end of the session, Andrew was energized. "Rob, I see it now," he said. "I've been sitting on a goldmine without even realizing it."

"That's the beauty of the Sunflower Code," Rob replied with a grin. "It's not about me handing you a solution—it's about helping you see what all was there along."

And it wasn't long before Andrew's company landed a $10 million contract, a deal that transformed his business almost overnight.

Rob's phone started ringing more frequently. Entrepreneurs, both big and small, were hearing about his methods, and they all wanted a piece of the Sunflower wisdom. But Rob never saw himself as the man with all the answers. His role was to ask the questions that would lead others to discover their own truths.

One day, after finishing a session with a small-time entrepreneur, Rob turned to Terry. "You know, I'm starting to think that I can grow a new petal."

Terry looked at him, intrigued. "What do you mean?"

"I think it's time to put the Sunflower Code into a book," Rob said thoughtfully. "Something that any entrepreneur can pick up and use. I'll teach them how to ask the right questions, how to analyze their strengths, and how to find the right direction for their business. That way, even if I can't meet with every single one of them, I can still help them succeed."

Terry nodded, a smile forming on her face. "That sounds perfect, Rob. You can't clone yourself, but you can certainly scale your wisdom. You've always been about helping people grow."

He started writing, pouring the Sunflower Code into a book that would become a bible for aspiring entrepreneurs. He helped people not by giving them a map, but by teaching them how to draw their own.

Then, one day, the phone rang again. This time, it wasn't an entrepreneur. It was a call from Cornell University.

"Mr. Ryan, we've been following your work, and we'd love for you to come and teach our students about the Sunflower Code. We believe your insights could change the way future entrepreneurs think about business."

Rob hung up the phone and turned to Terry with a grin. "Looks like I've got a new petal honey."

Chapter 21: A New Challenge

The car rolled slowly through the streets of Ithaca, its occupants lost in thought as they passed familiar landmarks. Rob glanced out the window, a mix of nostalgia and curiosity flickering across his face. "That's the corner where you first asked me out," Terry said with a playful smile, breaking the silence.

Rob chuckled, shaking his head. "What are you talking about? We were just friends back then. You were still dating that hippie poet."

Terry raised an eyebrow. "He wasn't a hippie; he was creative."

"Lucky, I stole you away," Rob replied, glancing at her, "or you might be boiling water on some commune in the Catskills right now."

Terry laughed, leaning back in her seat. "You know, even though we met and got married here, I don't actually remember you proposing to me."

"That's because you proposed to me," Rob shot back with a mischievous grin.

"Don't start with that nonsense again," Terry replied, rolling her eyes.

Rob shrugged. "I'm not proud of it, but getting down on one knee, all romantic—it's just not me."

"I'll give you that," Terry said with a smirk. "How many times did you forget to send me flowers on our anniversary?"

"Couldn't tell you," Rob admitted.

"Like today," Terry added casually.

Rob furrowed his brow. "Today? What's so special about today?"

Terry raised an eyebrow, a playful smirk on her lips. "What's today's date, Rob?"

A quick squeal of brakes jolted Terry forward as Rob abruptly stopped the car in surprise.

"What happened, Rob?" she asked, her voice laced with panic.

Rob grinned sheepishly. "You're right. Today is a day to celebrate... and what better way than with a glass of sweet, fresh lemonade? A perfect symbol of a relationship that's had its sour moments, but in the end, it's sweet and refreshing." He winked.

Terry looked at him, confused. "What are you talking about?"

"Our life, Terry. Our amazing, wonderfully quirky life." Rob pointed to a little lemonade stand just ahead, where three kids stood proudly behind a table. "And this delightful lemonade stand! What better way to toast our anniversary?"

Terry shook her head with a smile. "So, this is how you suggest we celebrate our marriage? Lemonade from a roadside stand? You never fail to surprise me."

Rob chuckled, easing the car closer to the stand and rolling down the window. "Hey, we're celebrating our anniversary! How much for some of your finest bubbly?" he called out to the kids.

"Five bucks for a sweet, fresh lemonade!" the first kid exclaimed confidently.

"Five bucks?" Rob feigned shock, laughing. "Is it magical or something?"

"You bet!" the kid grinned, clearly proud. "We use only fresh lemons, and there are raspberries too! We picked them ourselves."

"Raspberries have potassium, which lowers blood pressure," added another kid, as if revealing a secret health benefit.

Rob laughed. "Alright, you've got me. Two lemonades, please!"

As the kids poured the drinks, Rob handed them a twenty-dollar bill. "Keep the change," he said with a wink. "You've got a winning formula here."

Then, Rob noticed a sign on the table: "Used Golf Balls. 3 for $9."

"Hey, I see you've got another business here... selling used golf balls?"

The salesgirl nodded confidently. "Yep! We collect the ones golfers lose at the nearby course and sell them. It's a good deal. Want to buy some?"

A grin spread across Rob's face, old memories of his own entrepreneurial beginnings flooding back. "But you only sell the ones golfers don't bother to collect, right? No shortcuts?"

The girl stood tall, nodding. "No sir, only the ones they leave behind."

Rob chuckled. "Smart choice. Honesty's key. Always play fair."

As they drove away, Rob turned to Terry, still smiling. "You know, those kids? They're already using the Sunflower Code. One's got the lemons, another handles marketing, and the third's good with words. And they've turned lost golf balls into a new petal for their business. The Sunflower Code—it's as simple as child's play."

Terry smiled, shaking her head in amusement. "Even kids get it. It really is that simple."---

---

Later that day, Rob and Terry entered to Cornell University's auditorium. He is going to give his first guest lecture. The room was packed with eager students, their eyes fixed on him as he stood at the front, relaxed but serious.

"You see," Rob began, "Even those three kids selling lemonade we meet in our way here, understand the Sunflower Code's rules. They used their core strengths—one had the lemons, one had the marketing knowledge, and one had the words. It's that simple."

A student raised her hand. "And that's the same method you used to save the internet?"

Rob smiled. "Yeah, it's hard to imagine the world without it now, right?"

Before he could continue, another student jumped up. "But it's not all for the better," the student said, his voice tinged with anger.

Rob paused, curious. "What do you mean?"

"The internet," the student continued, "is responsible for so much pain now. Bullying, fake news, trolling—people can hurt each other without consequence. Does that make you proud?"

The room fell silent, tension hanging in the air.

Rob took a deep breath, feeling the weight of the question. "Look," he began slowly, "the internet is a tool, and like any tool, it can be used for good or for harm. But—"

"Good?" the student interrupted, holding up a poster. It was a picture of a young boy, the words "How the Internet Killed Me" emblazoned beneath it. "That's my younger brother. He took his own life after being bullied online."

Rob's heart sank. "I'm so sorry," he said quietly. "How old was he?"

"Sixteen," the student replied, his voice breaking. "His only crime was that he stuttered."

Rob stood there for a moment, lost in thought. Terry watched him from the back of the room, her heart aching. The other students sat in stunned silence.

Rob finally spoke, his voice low but steady. "The internet has its dark sides, and I won't deny that. But it's also a tool that can create connection, build communities. It's no longer just about me, or even my generation. It's your world now."

Another student spoke up. "So, what do we do?"

Rob nodded, meeting their eyes. "It's like creating a new life. At some point, it no longer belongs to you. You're not in control of it anymore. It becomes whatever it becomes."

"No. No! It's your responsibility to put the genie back in the bottle! Isn't it?" the grieving brother demanded.

"The solution isn't destroying technology that has the potential to change our lives for the better, just because there are challenges," Rob replied, trying to inject reason into the heated conversation.

"You can't just ignore the evil with the good!" the brother shot back, his voice filled with frustration.

"Of course not," Rob agreed. "But we have to find a way to harness the good and eliminate the bad. And I can't do that alone. Like anything worthwhile, it has to be a team effort. I'm ready to help, but now it's your turn. You need to step up and take action."

"How do we deal with it?" another student asked, doubt creeping into their voice. "We're just a few people, and the internet is full of millions of anonymous, crazy people."

"This is exactly where the strength of the Sunflower Code comes in," Rob responded. "We need to build a strong team—some with tech backgrounds, some with creative content skills, others who understand the social networks, and many more who can bring different strengths to the table. With that set of core competencies, we can develop endless petals—tools that can be used in our campaign for a safer internet."

"I'm not sure we can win that battle," another student said quietly.

"If we don't try, we'll never know," Rob answered, looking around the room. "I'm here. Who's willing to join?"

One by one, the students stood, nodding in agreement, their determination growing. Rob watched them, knowing that his role wasn't to solve this problem for them, but to ask the right questions and inspire them to find the answers themselves.

In this final chapter, we can weave together the themes of mentorship, entrepreneurship, and life-changing experiences by integrating Rob's involvement with Ori and Irit Yardeni's *Life Changing Experiences* initiative. This collaboration will mark the next step in Rob's journey, where he focuses not only on teaching entrepreneurs but also on shaping the next generation of leaders and innovators.

Chapter 22: Meeting of Minds

The plane descended slowly into the lush paradise of Hawaii, its wings slicing through clouds like soft cotton. Ori Yardeni, gazing out of the window, felt the familiar rush of anticipation. He had traveled extensively, met countless innovators, and pioneered media projects that had changed lives across five continents, but something about this trip felt different. There was a spark, a gut feeling, that he needed to meet Rob Ryan.

He turned to his wife, Irit, who sat beside him, leafing through a book. “Irit, you know this isn’t just another business trip. I need you with me for this one.”

Irit barely looked up. “Hawaii again, Ori… well, as you know, it's not my favorite destination. Sure, it’s nice here, but 24 hours of flights with stopovers, all for three days? Definitely not paradise in my book.”

“I know, I know,” Ori chuckled. “But there’s something about this guy, Rob Ryan. I feel it in the air… He’s different. He’s not just any entrepreneur; this man saved the internet! His company sold for $24 billion, and now he’s teaching entrepreneurs how to grow their businesses using some kind of magic trick he calls the ‘Sunflower Code.’ Sounds mysterious, huh? Like *The Da Vinci Code*—remember that movie?”

“Everything in your life is like a movie, isn't it?” Irit teased, smirking as she remembered an old magazine article that had labeled him “Always Living in a Dream World.”

Ori laughed. “What’s so bad about living in a world of fantasy, especially since I tend to turn those dreams into reality? What’s going to stop me this time? Especially when I have you and your X-ray vision by my side. Your sixth sense is going to tell me if this mega tech guy is someone we can work with.”

Irit sighed but couldn’t help smiling. “Alright, alright. If I have to be the human truth detector again, I’ll do it.”

***

The next day, Ori and Irit found themselves in a sleek, modern conference room of an upscale Hawaiian hotel, waiting for their meeting with Rob Ryan. Ori was anxious but excited, mentally rehearsing how he would present his life’s work to one of the tech world’s most respected minds. As usual, he had set up his unique 3D presentation system—his secret weapon that had wowed everyone, from corporate giants to global organizations.

When Rob entered, his energy filled the room. With a quiet confidence, he greeted them warmly. “Ori, Irit, I’ve heard about you, but I’m not sure my people quite captured it all. I’m curious—what brings you here?”

Ori jumped straight into his pitch. He had done this a thousand times, but today, there was something more at stake. He introduced himself as a media entrepreneur whose 3D films and interactive experiences were used worldwide to change the behavior of young people in areas such as drug prevention, reckless driving, and anti-bullying campaigns.

"Our multi-sensory experiences aren’t just entertainment, Rob," Ori explained with his usual passion. "We are the kings of Edutainment. We speak directly to youth in their language, using

storytelling to help them understand the dangers they face and, more importantly, how to avoid them. It's all research-based, with measurable impact."

Rob listened intently, leaning in. "So, you're saying your films don't just entertain—they change behavior? You've got my attention. But how do you measure that impact?"

Ori smiled. "We conduct research before and after every project. We survey schools, follow up with communities, and collaborate with leading research teams to ensure that what we're doing works. It's about leaving a lasting change in their behavior, and the numbers speak for themselves."

Rob nodded, clearly impressed but still skeptical. He stood and moved to the whiteboard. "Let's break this down using the Sunflower Code."

He drew the outline of a sunflower and labeled the center, "Storyteller."

"You're a storyteller, Ori. That's your core identity, your seed. Everything you've done grows from that."

Rob added petals to the drawing. "You've created films, immersive experiences, exhibitions, educational centers… Each of these is a petal, extending from your storytelling. And now, you're tackling behavior change in teenagers. That's another petal. You're using your storytelling to impact lives. That's pretty impressive."

Ori leaned forward, eager to hear more. "But?"

"But," Rob said, pausing with a marker in hand, "there's one problem with your model."

Ori raised an eyebrow. "What's that?"

"You're working with the one sector I avoid like the plague—governments and public institutions. Bureaucrats with no vision, no sense of urgency. I've spent my whole career steering clear of that. I thrive in the fast-paced world of business. Government? That's not for me."

Ori wasn't surprised but wasn't deterred either. "I get that. Governments are slow-moving beasts, but when you're trying to create societal change, they're necessary. You need their backing to scale solutions that can make a real impact. And, to be honest, it's a little satisfying using their resources to actually do some good."

Rob smiled but shook his head. "Yeah, it's impressive what you've managed, but it's not my thing. I'm a business guy. That's where I belong."

After Rob and his team left the room, Irit turned to Ori. "It's not going to be an easy task."

"Life was never meant to be easy," Ori replied with his signature optimism. "We've got a mission, and we'll push forward."

***

The following day, after listening to Rob's seminars for a day and a half, Ori and Irit joined a small gathering to celebrate the end of the retreat. Rob approached them, clearly curious. "So, was the long flight worth it?"

Ori, ever direct, didn't hold back. "Look, Rob, your ideas are brilliant. The Sunflower Code is powerful. But if I'm being honest—and where I come from, we say what we think—I felt something was missing."

Rob raised an eyebrow, clearly intrigued. "Missing?"

"Yeah," Ori continued. "You're surrounded by people who are all about making money, and that's fine, but where's the humanity? The values? Business success is great, but what about the bigger picture? What about using this code to help non-profits, to improve lives—not just balance sheets?"

Rob blinked, taken aback by Ori's bluntness. "So, you don't like me?"

"I thought I didn't," Ori admitted. "But my secret weapon—my wife here—tells me otherwise."

Irit smiled and added softly, "Rob, I think all this business talk is just a mask. Inside, I see a man of deep values, someone who cares. You've probably just built up some walls over time, but underneath, you're full of heart."

Rob laughed, taking Irit's hand. "I'm glad you brought her along, Ori. I was starting to think you were just here to bust my chops!"

The room filled with laughter, and for a moment, it seemed like the ice had truly broken.

But Ori wasn't done. "Rob, I've heard your vision for creating a million entrepreneurs. It's ambitious, and I love big goals. But you can't get there by training ten CEOs at a time. You need to think bigger—and there's only one person who can help you with that."

Rob grinned, sensing where this was going. "Who?"

Ori smiled back. "You're looking at him."

"And how exactly do you plan to help me?" Rob asked, half-doubting but half-intrigued.

"I've got direct access to millions of students worldwide. Right now, I'm teaching them what not to do—don't take drugs, don't drink and drive—but with your help, I can start teaching them what to do. How to dream big, how to use the Sunflower Code to build their futures."

Rob hesitated. "High school students? I'm not sure that's the best use of my time. I'm more interested in university students—people at Cornell, for example, who are ready to innovate."

"You're missing something important," Ori said. "The university students have already made their decisions. They're going to become entrepreneurs with or without you. But if you want to reach your goal of a million, you need to start earlier. Show these young people that they can be more, that they don't need money or connections to start. They just need to know how to tap into their potential."

Rob leaned back, considering. “I don’t know… Let me think about it.”

Ori didn’t miss a beat. “Is that your polite American way of saying, ‘Thanks, but no thanks?’”

Rob smiled. “You really do say what you think in the Mediterranean, huh? I like that.”

They shook hands, and while Rob went home, Irit and Ori returned to their hotel, unsure of what would come next.

***

The next morning, as Ori prepared for a relaxing snorkel, an email notification popped up on his laptop. The sender? Rob Ryan. The message contained just three words: “Ori… students… thoughts?”

“Bingo!” Ori shouted to Irit in the other room. “Rob’s interested!”

But what did Rob mean exactly? Ori had learned by now that Rob’s emails were always cryptic puzzles, full of missing pieces.

After exchanging about 20 more emails in the span of an hour, Rob’s final message came through: “Oops, it’s started raining.”

Ori laughed and replied, “Guess my snorkeling is canceled. I have to stay in my room”

“No, You are not staying in your room,” Rob shot back. “Meet me in the hotel lobby. I’ll be there in fifteen.”

Fifteen minutes later, Ori and Rob met in the lobby. Rob looked around. “Where’s your wife, Irit?”

“She’s in the gym,” Ori replied.

“No, no, I need her here with you,” Rob laughed. “She’s the best translator you’ve got.”

The two sat and talked for three hours. By the end of the conversation, they had shaken hands and made a pact. They would create a program called *License to Dream*, a global educational initiative that would teach young people the principles of the Sunflower Code.

And so, a new partnership was born. Over the years, that partnership would blossom into several more projects, from *License to Dream* to the film *The Man Who Saved the Internet with a Sunflower*, and even this very book. Ori and Rob could look at their Sunflower with pride, knowing that together, they had grown something far greater than either could have done alone. The petals of their collaboration continued to unfold, one dream at a time.